



HAYATI

A Fairytale of the Two Kingdoms

STERRA
DREAMERS RISE

WHERE

HAYATI

A Fairytale of the Two Kingdoms



For the one I call Hayati.

*For every night distance could not defeat us,
for every time we found our way back,
for every prayer beneath the same moon,
and for the day when waiting becomes an embrace.*

THE WORLD OF THE STORY

Asterra is the kingdom where Abdulrahim lives as an ordinary commoner. Far away is Zahraan, the home of Princess Sun'dus. Between them lies the Faraway Realm, a magical land open to people from every kingdom. Each visitor receives a living book that can carry words, portraits, and chosen memories. With a special mirror spell, two distant people can see and hear one another in the same moment. The magic can bring hearts close, but it cannot turn light into touch.



THE MAGIC OF THE FARAWAY REALM

Living Books - carry words, portraits, and chosen memories.

Private Pages - can be opened by one chosen person only.

Mirror Spell - lets two distant people see and hear one another live.

True Gate - is the only magic that can make distance become touch.

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Two kingdoms. One magical realm. A love written across distance.





The Book With No Memories

There were two kingdoms so far apart that no road joined them.

Asterra stood between blue mountains and cold rivers. Its people lived in stone houses with sloping roofs, and most of them knew the sound of market bells better than the sound of palace music. Abdulrahim was one of them. He was not a prince, a knight, or the son of a famous family. He was an ordinary young man with studies to finish, dreams he did not always speak about, and a habit of thinking too much about almost everything.

Far beyond Asterra, past deserts, seas, and lands Abdulrahim had never seen, stood the kingdom of Zahraan.

Zahraan was warmer. Its palace rose above gardens of roses and jasmine. White towers caught the evening light, and fountains ran through courtyards where the moon could be seen in the water.

In that palace lived Princess Sun'dus.

But Abdulrahim did not know that yet.

Between Asterra, Zahraan, and every other kingdom in the world was a place called the Faraway Realm. It belonged to no king.

No army guarded it.

No ship could sail there and no horse could reach it.

People entered it through enchanted gates hidden in their own kingdoms. When someone stepped through one of those gates, their real body remained safely at home. Only a light-form of them entered the Realm.

That was why people from opposite sides of the world could walk through the same garden, sit beside the same fountain, and speak as if distance did not exist.

They could see one another.

They could hear one another.

They could laugh together.

But they could not truly touch.

A hand placed against another would pass through like moonlight through mist.

The first time anyone entered the Faraway Realm, they were given a magical book.

The books were beautiful things. Their covers changed with their owners. Their pages could hold words, portraits, and even memories. A person could place a memory on a page and allow others to watch it for a few moments: a birthday in a distant city, a walk beside the sea, a face smiling at a window, a meal shared with family, a sunset, a joke, a quiet day.

Some people filled hundreds of pages.
They liked being known.

Abdulrahim did not.

His book had a dark blue cover with a thin silver line around the edge. On the first night he received it, the book asked him a simple question in glowing letters.

WHAT WOULD YOU LIKE THE WORLD TO KNOW
ABOUT YOU?

Abdulrahim stared at the page.

"Nothing," he said.

The letters disappeared.

The book remained almost completely blank.
He liked it that way.

He did not mind speaking to people. He simply disliked the idea of strangers opening a book and walking through pieces of his life before they had earned the right to know him.

For a while he visited the Faraway Realm without giving anyone much to see. He wandered through moon gardens, crossed bridges made of pale glass, and watched people from kingdoms he had only read about. He spoke when he felt like speaking and disappeared when he had enough.

Then one evening he entered a public gathering in a round court beneath a ceiling of stars.

The gathering had one rule. Everyone had to give a short introduction and open at least one page of their memory book.

Visitors sat in a wide circle. One by one, books floated open above their hands. A boy showed a memory of a mountain village. A girl showed herself riding beside the sea. Someone else showed a family garden covered in spring flowers.

Then it was Abdulrahim's turn.

He gave his name.

"And your page?" someone asked.

"No page."

Several people laughed.

"Everyone shows one."

"Then I will be the exception."

His blank book rested calmly in his hands.

People began telling him to stop being difficult.

He refused.

They insisted.

He refused again.

Then a girl's voice came from the other side of the circle.

"Why bring a memory book if you plan to keep every page empty?"

Abdulrahim looked across the court.

He could not see her clearly. The light of the gathering floated between them, and several people sat in the way.

"Because the book came with the Realm," he said.

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only one you are getting."

"So you are hiding."

"I am private."

"That sounds like a nicer word for hiding."

A few people laughed again.

Abdulrahim leaned back. "Why do you care so much?"

"I don't."

"You have argued with me three times."

"Because you are stubborn."

"And you are still arguing."

There was a pause.

"Maybe you are also stubborn," he added.

This time he heard her laugh.

It was a small sound, but for some reason he remembered it after the gathering ended.

Abdulrahim left without opening a single memory.

He should have forgotten the girl.

Instead, he became curious.

The Faraway Realm allowed every visitor to keep a public shelf. Anyone who had spoken with them could ask their book to show what that person had chosen to share.

Abdulrahim told himself he was only checking because she had annoyed him.

His book did not believe him, but it opened anyway.
"Show me the girl from the gathering," he whispered.
The pages turned by themselves.
Then they stopped.

A name appeared in soft gold letters.
SUN'DUS.

Below it was a small royal crest.
Abdulrahim frowned.
He touched the crest.

The page opened into a living memory.
For a few seconds he saw a palace balcony in Zahraan.
Roses climbed a white wall. Evening light rested over a
wide garden. Then Sun'dus stepped into the memory.

Abdulrahim forgot the question he had been about to
ask.
It was not love.

Love had not had time to exist yet.
But something inside him became very still.
Her eyes caught him first. Then her smile. Then the
softness in her face.

She looked like the kind of woman he had imagined
in the quietest part of his mind long before he had ever
known her name.

The memory changed. Another page showed her
laughing at something outside the frame. Another

showed the edge of a book in her hands. Another showed flowers beside a palace window.

Only then did Abdulrahim understand the crest. "Princess," he said quietly.

The word should have made him close the book.

A commoner from Asterra had no reason to be thinking about a princess from Zahraan.

Instead, he opened her page again.

He looked at her once more.

Then he noticed a small silver symbol at the bottom of the page.

PRIVATE PAGE.

A private page could be sent to one person only. Nobody else could read it. Nobody else could see what was placed inside it.

Abdulrahim stared at the symbol.

He had refused to show his face to an entire gathering of strangers.

Now, for reasons he could not explain even to himself, he wanted to show it to one girl.

He opened his own empty book.

For the first time, he placed a memory inside.

It was simple: his face, the evening light of Asterra behind him, nothing more.

He sent it only to Sun'dus.
Then he wrote beneath it:

There. Now stop calling me a coward.
The page folded itself into silver light and vanished.
Abdulrahim immediately regretted sending it.
He closed his book.
Opened it again.
Closed it.
Walked across his room.
Opened it again.
A new line of gold appeared.
I never called you a coward.
He smiled.
Another line appeared.
I said you were hiding.
Abdulrahim sat down.
That was the first private page between them.
Neither of them knew how many would follow.



The Princess in the Pages

Their first conversation happened in writing.

The magic books carried each line across the world almost as soon as it was written. Ink appeared in Abdulrahim's book in Zahraan's soft gold. His replies appeared in Sun'dus's book in Asterra's silver-blue.

For the first few minutes they argued about the same thing that had started everything.

You were hiding, Sun'dus wrote.

I was protecting my peace.

Very dramatic.

Says the princess.

The page stayed blank for several seconds.

Then:

So you noticed.

There was a royal crest on your book.

Maybe I put it there to impress you.

It did not work.

Liar.

Abdulrahim laughed out loud.

The Faraway Realm was supposed to make distant kingdoms feel less distant. The books did something even stranger. They made conversation follow people home.

He could be in Asterra, walking back from his studies, and feel the book warm beneath his arm. He would open it and find a message from Sun'dus.

She could be in Zahraan, sitting near a palace window, and a silver sentence would appear on a blank page.

At first they wrote about simple things.

Why he disliked sharing memories with strangers.

Why she had cared enough to keep bothering him.

Their kingdoms.

Food.

Weather.

Things they found annoying.

Things that made them laugh.

Abdulrahim learned quickly that being a princess did not make Sun'dus gentle all the time.

She could be stubborn enough to argue for ten minutes over something that did not matter.

She could answer one of his long explanations with two words and somehow make those two words win the argument.

She could also listen in a way he was not used to.

When he wrote about something difficult, she did not rush to change the subject. She asked questions. She remembered what he had told her. Days later she would return to it.

How did that thing go?
Are you feeling better today?
Did you finally eat properly?
That last question appeared often.

Sun'dus also began opening more pages of her
memory book to him.

Not to everyone.

To him.

A memory of rain touching the palace garden.

A plate of food she liked.

A new dress laid across a chair.

A sunset seen from a balcony.

A tired smile after a long day.

Sometimes there was no explanation at all.

Just a page.

Abdulrahim saved every one.

His own book slowly changed too.

The book that had once been almost empty began
filling with private pages meant for one person.

He sent Sun'dus the mountains beyond Asterra.

The street outside his home after rain.

A foolish face after studying too long.

A view of the moon above the rooftops.

Once, he sent a memory of himself laughing before he
realized the book had captured it.

Sun'dus replied immediately.

Keep that one.

Why?

You look happy.

I was.

Why?

Abdulrahim stared at the page for a moment.

Then he wrote:

I was talking to you.

The book went quiet.

When her reply came, it was only one line.

You are learning to be dangerous.

He smiled for the rest of the evening.

The more they spoke, the less important the difference between princess and commoner seemed inside the Faraway Realm.

Outside it, the difference was enormous.

Sun'dus lived behind palace walls. Her days included lessons, family duties, formal meals, and people who expected certain things from her because of the family she had been born into.

Abdulrahim's life was simpler. He studied, walked ordinary streets, worried about his future, and dreamed about building something successful with his own hands.

Inside their private pages, however, none of that mattered.

She was Sun'dus.

He was Abdulrahim.

That was enough.

One evening he asked her why she did not fill her public book with more royal memories.

Because then people speak to the crown before they speak to me, she wrote.

Abdulrahim read the sentence twice.

Then he answered:

I spoke to you before I knew.

Exactly.

You were still annoying.

And you still messaged me.

That part was difficult to argue with.

Their private pages became a habit.

Good morning appeared before the day properly began.

How are you?

Did you eat?

Where did you disappear to?

Look at this.

Listen to what happened.

I am tired.

I miss talking to you.

They began to know the shape of each other's days.

Abdulrahim knew when Sun'dus was busy by the way her replies became shorter. Sun'dus knew when he was overthinking because his questions became too careful.

She learned that when he said "nothing" after she asked what was wrong, it almost never meant nothing.

He learned that when she answered "I'm fine" too quickly, he should not always believe the words more than her silence.

This was how closeness arrived.

Not like lightning.

Like a room slowly filling with warm light.

One night, after many weeks of private pages, Sun'dus sent him a strange symbol.

It looked like a small mirror with a crescent moon drawn across it.

What is that? Abdulrahim wrote.

A spell.

That sounds safe.

It is, if you stop being dramatic.

What does it do?

The page waited long enough to make him impatient. Then her answer appeared.

It lets two connected books open a mirror between kingdoms.

Abdulrahim sat up.

A real mirror?

A seeing mirror. Voice too.

So I can see you now?

You already saw my memories.

That is not the same.

No, Sun'dus wrote. It isn't.

The next line appeared more slowly.

Do you want to try it?

Abdulrahim did not even pretend to think.

Yes.



The Private Page

Before they tried the mirror spell, they learned one more thing about their books.

A memory was not the same as a moment.

A memory could be chosen carefully. A person could decide when to open it, what to show, and when to close it again. That made the books beautiful, but also safe.

A live mirror would be different.

No perfect page.

No second chance to choose the better smile.

No hiding a tired face or an awkward silence.

For some reason, that made both of them nervous.

"You go first," Sun'dus wrote.

"You sent the spell."

"Exactly. I already contributed."

"That is not how this works."

"It is now."

Abdulrahim laughed.

He liked this version of her - the one who could turn an ordinary conversation into a small competition and somehow make him enjoy losing.

But they did not open the mirror that night.

Instead, they spent another week writing.

Later Abdulrahim would understand why those private pages mattered so much. They gave them a place to become close before seeing each other all the time. They learned each other's thoughts in words first.

Sun'dus would leave him long messages when something important was on her mind. Abdulrahim would answer with even longer ones. Sometimes they wrote until pages turned by themselves beneath their hands.

Other times their messages were foolish.

Sun'dus once sent him a memory of a plate of food.
"Why are you showing me this?"

"Because mine looks better than whatever you are eating."

"You don't even know what I am eating."

"Exactly. It must be worse."

He sent her his own meal.
Her reply came quickly.
"I was right."

Another day Abdulrahim sent a picture of the sky above Asterra.

Sun'dus sent back the sky above Zahraan.

The colors were different, but the moon was already visible in both.

"Same moon," he wrote.

"Different kingdoms," she replied.

"Still the same moon."

That sentence stayed with both of them.

Their books began to feel less like magical objects and more like places where pieces of their lives met.

Sun'dus's book had pages Abdulrahim would never see. Family memories. Private thoughts. Parts of herself she kept only for herself.

His book did too.

That mattered.

Closeness did not mean ownership.

They were learning each other by invitation.

One page at a time.

One evening Sun'dus sent a memory without warning.

She was smiling at something beyond the edge of the image. The light around her was soft. There was nothing grand in the scene, no royal dress, no palace ceremony. She simply looked happy.

Abdulrahim opened the memory again.

Then again.

When Sun'dus noticed, she wrote:

"How many times are you going to open that page?"

"I am studying something."

"My face?"

"Very serious research."

"And what have you discovered?"

He thought about making a joke.

Instead he wrote:

"That I like seeing you happy."

The book stayed still.

Then gold letters appeared.

"That was almost sweet."

"Almost?"

"Do not become proud."

Abdulrahim smiled.

The first thing he had noticed about Sun'dus was her beauty.

That was still true.

He loved her eyes. He loved her smile. He loved the softness of her face.

But now he was beginning to notice things a memory picture could not explain.

The patience in the way she listened.

The care in questions she remembered to ask days later.

The way she could make him feel important simply by paying attention.

He began looking for her pages whenever his own day became heavy.

Not because she could solve everything.

Because she made him feel less alone inside it.

The book also brought out parts of Abdulrahim that Sun'dus learned quickly.

He was emotional.

Protective.

Romantic when he forgot to be embarrassed about it.

Stubborn when he believed he was right.

Quiet when something hurt him too much.

Too quick to imagine problems when a reply took longer than he expected.

Sun'dus once wrote:

"You think too much."

"I think the correct amount."

"You think about a thought, then think about why you thought it, then worry about what the thought might mean."

"That sounds responsible."

"That sounds tiring."

She was right.

He knew it.

He argued anyway.

Their books became full of those moments.

Good mornings.

Late messages.

Long apologies for small misunderstandings.

Pictures of ordinary days.

Random thoughts.

Private jokes.

Small acts of care.

The kind of things that looked unimportant alone and became a whole relationship when placed together.

Then, one night, Sun'dus sent the crescent-mirror symbol again.

This time there was only one sentence beneath it.

"Stop delaying."

Abdulrahim smiled.

"You were the nervous one."

"Not anymore."

"Fine. Tonight."

The page glowed.

The mirror spell had begun.



The Mirror Spell

The spell required both books to be open to the same page.

Sun'dus drew half a silver crescent on hers.

Abdulrahim drew the other half on his.

The pages brightened.

For a moment nothing happened.

Then the small mirror in Abdulrahim's room turned black.

A circle of moonlight appeared at its center.

The light widened slowly until the glass looked deeper than glass should ever look.

Abdulrahim saw a room he had never entered.

Warm light.

A pale wall.

The edge of a curtain.

Then Sun'dus stepped into view.

Both of them went quiet.

They had seen each other in memories many times.

This was different.

This was now.

Sun'dus looked at him through the spell and immediately smiled.

"So," she said, "you are real."

Abdulrahim laughed. "You sound surprised."

"Your book was empty when I met you. I had reasons to be suspicious."

"You are the princess talking to strangers in a magical realm."

"One stranger."

The answer landed more softly than she meant it to.

Abdulrahim looked at her for a second longer.

"One?"

Sun'dus rolled her eyes. "Do not start."

That first mirror conversation lasted much longer than either planned.

They talked about things they had already written about, yet hearing the words made them feel new.

Abdulrahim learned the small changes in Sun'dus's expression when she was teasing him.

Sun'dus learned how obvious his face became when he was pretending not to care about something.

They laughed more.

They interrupted each other.

They sat in silence without needing to write another sentence just to keep the connection alive.

After that night, the mirror spell became part of their lives.

The magic books remained their private road for messages and memories. The mirrors became their windows.

One evening they tried something new with their books. Instead of sending a portrait, Abdulrahim placed a quiet memory onto a private page: rain falling over the roofs of Asterra while he stood beneath a narrow awning, watching the street shine. There was nothing grand in it. No palace. No festival. Just the sound of water, the smell of wet stone, and a moment he had liked enough to remember.

Sun'dus watched the memory from Zahraan. When it ended, a new page appeared in his book. Hers.

She had sent the view from a high palace balcony after everyone else had gone inside. The city below was almost dark. The gardens were silver under the moon. For a few seconds, Abdulrahim saw the world exactly as she had seen it.

"So this is what your night looks like," he said when the mirror opened later.

"And yours sounds like rain."

"That is because mine is better."

"You showed me a wet street."

"A beautiful wet street."

She laughed.

After that, they stopped using memories only to show important things. They sent ordinary pieces of life: a cup

beside a book, light through a window, a road walked many times, flowers after rain, the sky before sleep. Those small pages made their kingdoms feel less like places on opposite ends of the world. They became rooms in one larger life they were slowly learning to share.

In the morning, Sun'dus might leave a gold message inside his book.

At night, they would open the mirror.

During the day, one of them might send a memory.

Later, the other would ask about it face to face through silver glass.

Sometimes they entered the Faraway Realm together and wandered through places neither kingdom possessed: a garden where flowers opened to music, a bridge above slow-moving clouds, a library whose books showed distant lands instead of words.

They still could not touch there.

Their light-forms passed through each other.

But they could walk side by side.

That was enough to make the impossible feel almost normal.

Soon their conversations became part of every day. "Did you eat?" Sun'dus asked one evening through the mirror.

Abdulrahim looked away.

"That means no."

"I was going to."

"When?"

"Soon."

"Go."

"You are very comfortable giving orders from another kingdom."

"I am a princess."

"There it is. Finally using the title."

"Only because you are difficult."

He complained, but he went.

When he returned, she was still there.

Another night Sun'dus appeared quieter than usual. Abdulrahim noticed immediately.

"What happened?"

"Nothing."

"That answer is illegal."

"In which kingdom?"

"Mine."

"Good thing I live in Zahraan."

He smiled but did not let the question disappear.

"You don't have to tell me everything," he said. "Just don't pretend with me if you don't want to."

Her expression softened.

Eventually she spoke.

He listened.

That became one of the ways they cared for each other: not with perfect answers, but with attention. They remembered little details.

A worry mentioned once would return days later.

A joke became a private language.

A page with no explanation meant I thought of you.

A quiet mirror call meant I have nothing important to say, but I still want you near.

Some nights they spoke until one of them became too tired to keep their eyes open.

"Go sleep," Abdulrahim told her once.

"I am awake."

"Your eyes are closed."

"I am thinking."

"With your whole face asleep?"

She opened one eye. "Maybe."

"Go."

"You first."

"Why?"

"Because if you close the mirror first, my room gets quiet."

Abdulrahim stopped smiling for a moment.

"And if you close it first," he said, "mine gets quiet."

Neither spoke.

They stayed connected.

A little later Sun'dus fell asleep.

Abdulrahim listened to the soft silence on the other side of the spell and smiled to himself.

He left the mirror open longer than necessary.
That became normal too.

Falling asleep while still connected across kingdoms.

Waking to messages in their books.

Sharing pieces of the day as if they were not separated by seas, borders, and years of travel.

The magic did not remove the distance.

It simply gave them ways to live inside it.

And somewhere between the private pages and the moonlit mirrors, Abdulrahim began to realize something he had not planned for.

He was not only waiting to hear from Sun'dus.

He was beginning to need the peace that came with her.



When Her Voice Became Home

Love did not arrive with music.

There was no sudden storm, no crown of stars, no voice from the sky telling Abdulrahim that his life had changed.

It happened more quietly than that.

It happened in repetition.

Sun'dus asking whether he had eaten.

Abdulrahim making her laugh when she had been upset.

A memory page appearing in his magic book in the middle of the day.

A message waiting for her when she woke.

Their voices finding each other at night.

The ordinary things became important because they belonged to them.

At first, Abdulrahim only knew that he liked speaking to her.

Then he knew that he missed her when they went too long without talking.

Then he knew that a good day felt better if he told her about it, and a bad day felt easier after hearing her voice.

Finally, one evening, he understood something that frightened him.

Sun'dus had not simply become someone he enjoyed.

She had become part of the way he felt peace.

That evening, he was walking through Asterra while the sun went down behind the mountains. He passed shops closing for the night and heard people speaking around him. The city was full. Nothing was wrong.

Yet he kept wondering when Sun'dus would open the mirror.

When a gold sentence appeared in his book telling him Sun'dus was free to open the mirror, his whole mood changed.

He stared at it for a second.

Then he laughed at himself.

"This is bad," he whispered.

He opened the seeing mirror.

Sun'dus appeared in the Rose Mirror Court.

"What is bad?" she asked.

"Nothing."

"You were smiling before I even arrived."

"Maybe I was having a very good evening."

"Without me?"

"Apparently not."

The answer came out before he could stop it.

Sun'dus went quiet.

Abdulrahim looked at the stream.

The water had begun to glow softly between them.
They changed the subject.
But something had shifted.

Over the following days, Abdulrahim became more aware of how deeply he cared. He worried about her. He wanted her to be happy. He became protective, sometimes too protective. When she was distant, he overthought it. When she disappeared for longer than expected, his mind invented reasons.

Sun'dus began to know this side of him too.

"You think too much," she told him once.

"I think the correct amount."

"No. You think about a thought, then think about why you thought it, then become worried about what the thought might mean."

"That sounds responsible."

"That sounds exhausting."

He laughed because she was right.

Another time, she was telling him about something ordinary when he stopped her.

"What?" she asked.

"Nothing."

"You are staring."

"I can see that."

"Why?"

He considered giving a clever answer.
Instead he said, "You look beautiful tonight."
Sun'dus looked away.

The roses behind her opened all at once.
Abdulrahim grinned.

"Do not start," she warned.

"I said nothing."

"Your face did."

They both laughed.

Moments like that made the truth stronger.
Abdulrahim had seen beautiful faces before.
That was not enough to explain what he felt.
Sun'dus made him comfortable.

She made him feel important without needing to say
it every day.

She listened.

She remembered.

She cared about what happened to him.

He began imagining her in parts of his future without
choosing to.

Not grand scenes at first.

Simple ones.

Telling her something in the same room instead of
through a mirror.

Hearing her laugh without silver glass between them.

Sitting beside her when neither had anything
important to say.

Holding her hand.

That last thought stayed longer than the others.

He looked at his own hand, then at hers resting on
the stone seat across the stream.

The distance between them was small inside the
Realm.

In the real world, it was enormous.

Abdulrahim reached forward without thinking.

His fingers passed through hers like light.

Sun'dus looked at him.

He pulled his hand back.

"Sorry."

"For what?"

"I forgot."

She looked at the place where their hands had failed
to meet.

"One day," she said softly.

Abdulrahim's heart moved before his mind did.

"One day," he repeated.

That was the night he stopped asking himself
whether he was falling in love.

He already had.

Once Abdulrahim understood that he loved her, he
became more careful and less careful at the same time.

More careful because every word from Sun'dus mattered more.

Less careful because his feelings began appearing in everything he said.

If she looked tired, he worried. If she sounded happy, he became happy with her. If she disappeared for a few hours, he noticed the absence too quickly.

Sun'dus noticed his change.

"You ask too many questions now," she told him.

"I have always asked questions."

"Not like this."

"Like what?"

"Where are you? Are you okay? Did you eat? Why are you quiet? Why did you say that? What does that mean?"

Abdulrahim tried not to smile. "That sounds like care."

"That sounds like investigation."

"Same family."

She shook her head.

But when Abdulrahim had a difficult day, Sun'dus asked just as many questions in her own way. She did not always say, Tell me everything. Sometimes she simply remained on the mirror longer. Sometimes she sent a message after they had already said goodnight. Sometimes she remembered the next morning and asked, Better today?

Those details made Abdulrahim feel seen.

He began thinking of home differently.

Asterra was still his kingdom. His room was still his room. His family, studies, streets, and future were there.

But home was also becoming a feeling.

The feeling of opening a mirror and seeing Sun'dus.

The feeling of hearing her call him by name after a long day.

The feeling of knowing there was someone far away who cared how his day had gone.

He did not tell her all of that at once. It would have sounded too heavy.

Instead, one night he said, "You know what is dangerous about you?"

Sun'dus looked suspicious. "What?"

"You became normal."

She stared at him. "That is your compliment?"

"Listen first. You were strange at the beginning. A princess from a kingdom I had never seen, first arguing with me over a blank magic book and later appearing in a magical mirror. Now if I do not hear your voice, the day feels strange."

Her expression changed.

"So I am normal?"

"No. You made yourself part of normal."

Sun'dus smiled slowly.

"That is better."

Abdulrahim looked at her through the moonlight.

He knew then that he would eventually have to tell her the truth.

He also knew the truth might change everything.



The Words He Said Too Soon

For several nights, Abdulrahim carried the same thought into the Faraway Realm and carried it back to Asterra again without speaking it.

He loved Sun'dus.

The words felt simple in his mind and dangerous in his mouth.

He knew she cared about him. He knew she trusted him. He knew she looked for him when he was late and noticed when his mood changed. But caring was not the same as being ready for love, and Abdulrahim did not know whether her heart had reached the same place as his.

Still, he was never very good at hiding strong feelings for long.

One evening the Rose Mirror Court was unusually quiet. A soft rain fell in Asterra, and the mirror behind Abdulrahim showed silver drops on his window. In Zahraan the night was clear. Sun'dus sat with one hand beneath her chin, watching him talk about something he could no longer remember later.

He stopped in the middle of a sentence.
"Why are you looking at me like that?" she asked.
"Like what?"

"Like you forgot what you were saying."

He had.

Abdulrahim looked down at the stream.

The stars inside the water were moving slowly.

"Sun'dus."

Her expression changed. She knew from his voice that this was not another joke.

"Yes?"

He could have waited.

Maybe he should have.

Instead he said it.

"I love you."

The Faraway Realm became very still.

Even the water seemed to stop moving.

Sun'dus did not smile.

She did not become angry either.

She simply looked at him for a long moment, and Abdulrahim understood before she spoke that he would not hear the answer he wanted.

"Abdulrahim..."

He forced himself not to look away.

"I care about you," she said. "You know I do. But I am not ready for a relationship."

The words did not sound cruel.

That almost made them harder.

He nodded once.

"Okay."

Sun'dus leaned forward. "I don't want to hurt you."

"You didn't do anything wrong."

"You sound hurt."

"Because I am. That doesn't mean you did something wrong."

He tried to smile. It did not work very well.

Sun'dus was quiet.

Abdulrahim suddenly felt foolish for every hope he had allowed himself to build. He had imagined that maybe she was only waiting for him to say the words first. He had imagined that the moment would make everything clear.

Instead, the truth was simple.

He loved her.

She was not ready to choose that kind of love with him.

And he could not argue with her heart.

That night ended earlier than usual.

When Abdulrahim returned to Asterra, he covered his seeing mirror with a dark cloth.

The next evening he did not enter the Realm.

He did not enter the evening after that either.

For the first time in months, his nights were empty.

He told himself this was better. He needed distance.

He needed to stop hoping. He needed to remember what

his life had felt like before Sun'dus became part of every day.

But the silence did not feel clean.

It felt like walking through a familiar room after someone had taken all the furniture away.

He missed her jokes.

He missed the way she listened.

He missed asking about her day.

He missed hearing her ask about his.

Most of all, he hated the thought that his confession might have destroyed something good.

After a few days, Abdulrahim stood in front of the covered mirror for a long time.

He pulled the cloth away.

The glass remained dark until he touched it.

Then the silver doorway appeared.

He stepped into the Faraway Realm.

The Rose Mirror Court was empty.

For one terrible moment, he thought Sun'dus had stopped coming too.

Then her doorway opened.

She appeared on the other side of the stream.

Neither spoke immediately.

Sun'dus was the first to break the silence.

"Hi."

"Hi."

"You disappeared."

"I know."

"I thought you were angry."

"I was disappointed. Not angry with you."

She looked down.

Abdulrahim took a slow breath.

"I don't want to lose you because I said something you couldn't say back."

Sun'dus looked up again.

"What do you want?"

He answered honestly.

"I want what we had before I made it complicated."

"Can you do that?"

He almost said yes too quickly.

Instead he thought about it.

"I can try."

That answer was enough.

They spoke for a little while. Carefully at first. The conversation felt like walking over thin ice. But then Sun'dus said something that made Abdulrahim laugh. He replied with something that made her roll her eyes. A few minutes later, the old rhythm returned.

Not completely.

His love had not disappeared.

But something important had changed inside him.

He understood that loving Sun'dus did not give him the right to demand that she be ready when he was ready.

If she wanted friendship, he would respect that.

If she needed time, he would not try to force time to move faster.

He could be hurt and still be kind.

He could love her and still let her choose.

That lesson would become one of the hardest and most important parts of their story.

When they said goodnight, Sun'dus paused before leaving.

"I'm glad you came back."

Abdulrahim smiled.

"Me too."

The silver doorway closed.

He stood alone beside the stream, still loving her, still unsure what the future would become.

But for the first time since his confession, he felt peace.

He had not gotten the answer he wanted.

He had chosen not to turn love into pressure.

And somehow, that choice became the beginning of something deeper.

For the days after his return, Abdulrahim had to learn how to carry love without turning every conversation into a reminder of it.

It was harder than he expected.

There were moments when Sun'dus laughed and he wanted to tell her again. Moments when she listened to him and he thought, How can I not say it? Moments when she disappeared from the Realm and he had to stop himself from sending too many messages.

He began to understand that patience was not only waiting for a future day. Sometimes it was knowing what not to ask for today.

Sun'dus also became more open after the difficult conversation. Perhaps because Abdulrahim had respected her answer, she trusted that she could stay close without being forced into a promise.

That trust changed their friendship.

One night she asked, "Do you regret telling me?" Abdulrahim thought about it.

"No."

"Even though I said no?"

"I regret that it hurt. I don't regret being honest." She nodded slowly.

"And you don't hate me?"

He looked surprised. "Why would I hate you?" "Because I couldn't give you what you wanted."

Abdulrahim leaned forward.

"Sun'dus, if I only treated you well when you gave me what I wanted, that would not be love."

She looked down at her hands.

The roses beside her mirror moved in the wind.

That night they stayed together longer than they had since the confession.

The conversation was not romantic. It was better than that.

It was honest.

By the time they said goodnight, Abdulrahim understood that the rejection had not ended their story. It had changed its pace.

Maybe that was what they needed.

He had arrived at love quickly.

Sun'dus needed her own road.

If they were ever going to reach the same place, he could not drag her there.

He would walk beside her as long as she wanted him there.



The Friendship That Stayed

After the confession, they both tried to behave as if nothing had changed.

That did not work.

Everything had changed, even when they did not speak about it.

Abdulrahim no longer had to hide the fact that he loved her. Sun'dus no longer had to wonder whether his care meant more than friendship. The truth sat quietly between them, not as a demand, but as something known.

For a while, they became more careful.

Abdulrahim stopped saying things that sounded too romantic. Sun'dus avoided questions that might lead back to the confession. They talked about ordinary days, small problems, food, weather, dreams, and the strange things people did in the Faraway Realm, and the odd memories strangers chose to publish in their books.

But carefulness could not last forever between two people who had already become so comfortable.

Soon the jokes returned.

Then the long talks.

Then the late nights.

Sun'dus kept sending him private memory pages through the books. Abdulrahim kept saving them.

He still looked forward to her voice more than he wanted to admit.

One evening, she appeared in the mirror carrying a tired expression.

"Long day?" he asked.

"Very."

"Do you want to talk about it?"

"Not really."

"Do you want me to distract you?"

She looked at him. "Can you?"

"I am extremely talented."

"At being annoying."

"Exactly."

He spent the next hour making her laugh.

At the end, Sun'dus looked softer.

"Thank you," she said.

Abdulrahim shrugged. "For what?"

"For staying."

The words struck him more deeply than she seemed to know.

He did not answer with another confession.

He simply said, "Of course."

The friendship continued, but it slowly became difficult to name.

There were moments that felt like friendship.

There were moments that clearly felt like more.

Sun'dus began speaking to him with a tenderness she had once kept guarded. Abdulrahim began noticing that she sometimes waited for him to appear the way he waited for her. When he was late, she asked where he had been. When he was quiet, she asked what was wrong. When he pulled away after an argument, she did not always let him stay gone.

There was still no formal moment.

No royal announcement.

No promise under a bright sky.

No exact night when either could say, This is when we became us.

Love did not enter their story like a guest through a front door.

It grew inside the rooms they had already built together.

One night Abdulrahim said, "Do you realize we speak every day?"

Sun'dus looked amused. "You are only noticing now?"

"I mean every day."

"Yes. That is generally what every day means."

"You would miss me if I disappeared."

"Do not become confident."

"That is not a denial."

She smiled. "Goodnight, Abdulrahim."

"Again. Not a denial."

The mirror closed while he was still laughing.

Days like that became their normal life.

They began sending each other small messages through the Realm even when they did not have time to meet. The messages appeared as tiny lines of light on the edge of the seeing mirror.

Good morning.

Did you eat?

How are you?

Are you home?

I saw something that reminded me of you.

Call me when you can.

Sleep well.

Miss you.

The words were simple.

Together they built a world.

Abdulrahim understood more clearly now why his first confession had been too soon. He had loved Sun'dus before she was ready to trust the future he was imagining. Friendship gave that trust time to grow.

He learned more about her values, her care for family, her patience, and the life she hoped to have one day. She wanted comfort and success. She wanted a life

where she did not always have to count every dream against what she could afford. She wanted peace.

Abdulrahim listened to those dreams and quietly began placing himself inside the work needed to build them.

Not because Sun'dus had asked him to promise wealth.

Because he wanted to become someone who could give peace, not only speak about love.

Sun'dus also saw more of him.

She saw how emotional he could be beneath his jokes.

She saw the jealousy he tried to hide.

She saw the overthinking that could turn one small silence into ten imagined problems.

She saw how quickly he apologized when he believed he had hurt her.

She saw his stubbornness.

And she stayed close enough to know he was trying.

Their relationship had no clear starting line.

That would later become one of Abdulrahim's favorite things about it.

There was no single day on which friendship ended and love began.

There was only a long path, and at some point they looked around and realized they were walking it together.

The Faraway Realm gave them a simple way to stay close without making every meeting heavy. They began exploring it again, but now together.

There was a path where flowers opened only after hearing laughter. Abdulrahim made it his personal mission to cover the whole path in bloom. Sun'dus told him this was childish. She still followed him.

There was a library where books showed pictures of distant kingdoms instead of words. They spent one evening choosing places they wanted to see someday. "This one," Sun'dus said, touching a page that showed a city beside a bright sea.

"Too hot."

"You have not even been there."

"I can tell from the picture."

"Then you can stay home."

"You are going without me?"

"You said it is too hot."

Abdulrahim changed his mind immediately.

The book turned another page. Snow-covered mountains appeared.

"There," he said. "Better."

Sun'dus looked horrified. "No."

"You have not even been there."

She narrowed her eyes. "Do not use my words against me."

Those evenings were important because they let their friendship breathe. Abdulrahim did not spend every moment waiting for Sun'dus to become ready for a relationship. Sun'dus did not have to enter every conversation wondering whether he would ask again. They simply enjoyed each other.

And in that freedom, something new began happening.

Sun'dus started being the one to open the seeing mirror first more often. She began sending messages just because she missed him. She became more comfortable calling him affectionate names. She allowed warmth into places where she had once kept a careful boundary.

Abdulrahim noticed.

He did not rush to question it.
That was growth for him.

One night the two of them sat beside a pond filled with floating blue flowers. Sun'dus was quiet for so long that Abdulrahim finally asked, "What?"

"Nothing."

"That is my answer. You cannot use it."

She smiled. "I was thinking that I am glad you came back after I rejected you."

Abdulrahim looked at her.

"Me too."

"I thought you might never speak to me again."

"I thought about it."

"I know."

"But losing you completely felt worse."

Sun'dus looked at the flowers.

"Thank you for not making me feel guilty about it."

Abdulrahim answered gently. "You were allowed to say no."

That simple truth became another stone in the foundation beneath them.

Love had begun with attraction.

Trust was making it strong enough to last.



Love Without a Beginning Date

If anyone had asked them when they became a couple, neither could have given a perfect answer.

They had no date carved into stone.

No ceremony in the Faraway Realm.

No moment when the fountains suddenly turned gold and announced that friendship had become love.

It simply happened.

Abdulrahim noticed it first in the way Sun'dus's messages changed.

They became longer.

Softer.

More open.

She told him things she did not say to everyone. She allowed him closer to the parts of herself she usually kept hidden. Sometimes she said directly what she felt. Other times, Abdulrahim learned to hear it in the way she replied, the way she stayed, or the way she became quiet when something mattered too much.

He loved that hidden language.

He began to feel that he knew the Sun'dus behind the easy smile and the calm answers.

The girl who could hide sadness inside a short sentence.

The girl who cared deeply and sometimes protected that care by pretending she did not.

The girl whose real feelings often lived one layer beneath her words.

Abdulrahim was not always correct when he tried to read her. That caused problems later. But when he was right, Sun'dus would look at him through the mirror as if he had opened a door nobody else had noticed.

One night, after a long conversation, Abdulrahim opened a private page in his magic book and wrote three words.

I love you.

He had said it before, but this time the words felt different.

He was not asking a question.

He was not waiting for an answer that would prove anything.

He was simply telling the truth.

Sun'dus read the message.

A warm glow moved over the mirror.

Her reply appeared beneath his.

It was simple.

But this time, she did not step away from love.

After that, the language between them changed naturally.

They began speaking about each other as part of the future.

Not every day was serious. Most were not. They still teased each other.

Abdulrahim was usually the one trying to make her laugh. He could turn a normal conversation into nonsense without warning, and Sun'dus often pretended to be tired of him while clearly enjoying it.

Sometimes he would say something ridiculous just to hear the sound of her laugh through the magic.

Sometimes she would send him a picture without any explanation and wait for his reaction.

Sometimes they sat quietly, each doing something in their own kingdom while the private mirror remained open.

That might have been the strangest part of their love.

They lived far apart, yet they learned how to share ordinary time.

There was no need to make every moment romantic. Being present became romantic enough.

Abdulrahim began calling her when he woke.

Sun'dus became one of the last voices he wanted to hear before sleep.

When one of them had news, good or bad, the other often heard it quickly.

When one of them felt low, the other tried to lift the weight.

They checked on each other.

They reminded each other to eat.

They stayed awake too late.

They fell asleep with the mirrors still glowing.

They became close in all the ways distance allowed.

One evening, Abdulrahim said, "Do you know what is strange?"

"Everything about you?"

"Very funny."

"Thank you."

He smiled. "I mean us."

Sun'dus became quieter.

"What about us?"

"I don't remember when this became a relationship."

She thought for a moment.

"Maybe it didn't happen in one moment."

"That is what I mean."

"Then why do we need a moment?"

Abdulrahim looked at her.

Sun'dus continued, "Some things grow."

The words stayed with him.

Some things grow.

A seed does not announce the second it becomes a flower.

Morning does not arrive in one sharp line.
Love did not need a perfect beginning date to be real.
Their story had begun with stubbornness, curiosity,
and a private mirror.

Now it had become something neither wanted to lose.
Their relationship also changed in the way they
spoke about absence.

Before, if one of them became busy, they simply
returned later. Now they noticed the missing time.

"You disappeared," Abdulrahim would say.

"I was gone for two hours."

"Exactly."

"That is not disappearing."

"It is a small disappearance."

Sun'dus would laugh, but she began sending quick
messages when she knew she would be away. Not
because Abdulrahim had the right to demand it, but
because she understood that reassurance mattered to
him.

Abdulrahim, in return, had to learn that love did not
mean constant access. Sun'dus had a life in Zahraan that
continued beyond the mirror. Her family needed her.
Her studies needed her. She needed rest.
This balance took time.

Some days they handled it beautifully.
Other days they did not.

But even the mistakes showed that the relationship had become real enough to require care.

One evening Sun'dus sent Abdulrahim a long message through the mirror. It appeared as lines of gold across the glass. She wrote about how important he had become to her, how safe she felt speaking to him, and how strange it was that a person she had never physically met could understand so much of her life.

Abdulrahim read it once.

Then again.

Then a third time.

When Sun'dus appeared later, he tried to act normal. "Did you read it?" she asked.

"Maybe."

"Abdulrahim."

"Yes."

"And?"

He looked at her with a smile he could not hide. "I am keeping it forever."

Sun'dus covered part of her face with her hand. "I knew I should not have sent it."

"Too late."

"Delete it."

"Never."

He did keep it.

Years later, he would still remember the feeling of receiving those long messages in the early days. They were proof that Sun'dus was not simply allowing his love to exist near her anymore.

She was beginning to build something with him.

The Realm did not give them a date.

Their hearts did not need one.



Hayati

The first time the word truly mattered, it was late.

The Faraway Realm was almost empty. The public courts had gone quiet, and only a few visitors still sat beneath the silver trees with their magic books open.

Abdulrahim and Sun'dus were in their usual place.

They had spoken for hours, yet neither seemed ready to leave.

At some point, Sun'dus said the word.

"Hayati."

Abdulrahim looked up.

He knew the meaning.

My life.

It was a word people could say lightly. A word of affection. A soft name.

But from her, in that moment, it felt different.

"What did you call me?" he asked.

Sun'dus gave him a look. "You heard me."

"Say it again."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because now you are enjoying it too much."

He smiled. "Hayati."

She looked away.

"Now we are even."

From then on, the word belonged to both of them.

They used it when they were happy.

They used it when one needed comfort.

They used it in greetings and goodnights.

Sometimes they used it after an argument when neither was ready to say a long apology but both wanted the other to know the door was still open.

Hayati.

My life.

The word slowly became the name of the whole story they were building.

The Faraway Realm seemed to notice too.

One night, while they were speaking, a thin line of light appeared between their mirrors.

It began at the center of Abdulrahim's glass and crossed the stream like a golden thread. It reached Sun'dus's mirror and disappeared into the light around her.

They both stopped talking.

"Did you do that?" Sun'dus asked.

"No."

Abdulrahim reached toward the line.

His fingers passed through it, but the light moved as if touched by wind.

Sun'dus did the same from her side.

The thread brightened.

They laughed in surprise.

The Faraway Realm was full of strange magic, so they did not think the thread was a message from destiny or a promise that nothing could ever go wrong.

It was simply the Realm reflecting what had grown between them.

A connection.

Strong enough to be seen.

Still unable to become touch.

Abdulrahim loved the symbol, but Sun'dus understood something important first.

"It is beautiful," she said, "but it doesn't mean we can stop taking care of what we have."

He looked at her. "You always ruin my dramatic moments."

"Someone has to."

She smiled, then added, "A thread can still tangle." She was right.

Their love was real, but real love did not make them perfect.

Abdulrahim could be jealous even when Sun'dus had done nothing wrong. He could overthink a delayed reply. He could become quiet when hurt and expect her to understand what he had not explained.

Sun'dus could become distant when upset. She sometimes needed space just when Abdulrahim wanted answers. She could be stubborn enough to make a simple disagreement feel like a wall.

They were learning each other, but they were also learning themselves.

The golden thread did not protect them from that work.

It only reminded them that there was something worth protecting.

One night, after Sun'dus had spent a long time helping Abdulrahim through a difficult mood, he looked at the thread and said, "I understand the word now."

"What word?"

"Hayati."

She waited.

"It is not because my life would stop without you," he said. "I don't want to make you carry that."

Sun'dus listened carefully.

"It is because life feels more like mine when you are in it."

Her eyes softened.

Abdulrahim continued, "You make me care about tomorrow more."

For once, Sun'dus did not tease him.

"You do that for me too," she said.

The golden thread warmed between them.
And though they still had years ahead, mistakes ahead, fights ahead, and distance ahead, that night they understood one thing clearly.

They were no longer only two people who happened to meet in a magical garden.

They had become part of each other's idea of home.

Soon the name followed them everywhere.

"Good morning, Hayati."

"Did you eat, Hayati?"

"Stop overthinking, Hayati."

"Goodnight, Hayati."

It could sound playful or serious depending on how they said it. Sometimes it was almost a joke. Sometimes it carried everything they were too tired to explain.

One evening Abdulrahim entered the Realm upset after a difficult day. He did not want to talk about it. Sun'dus asked twice. He gave short answers. Eventually she stopped asking.

They sat beside the stream in silence.

After several minutes she said only, "Hayati."
Abdulrahim looked up.

There was no advice in the word. No question. It simply said, I am here.

His anger softened.

"Hayati," he answered.

That became one of the reasons he loved the name. It was small enough to fit inside any moment.

The golden thread appeared more often now. Sometimes it was bright. Sometimes it was so faint they forgot it was there. When they argued, it twisted. When they laughed, it moved lightly over the water.

Sun'dus once reached toward it and said, "People would probably think this is some sign that we cannot ever leave each other."

Abdulrahim smiled. "Is it not?"

"No."

"Very romantic."

"Listen. If we stop caring for each other, a glowing thread will not save us."

He looked at her more seriously.

"So what does it mean?"

Sun'dus thought for a moment.

"That something is there. What we do with it is still our choice."

Abdulrahim liked that answer.

It made their love feel more precious, not less.

They were not together because a spell forced two names into the same story. They were together because, after every ordinary day and every difficult one, they still wanted to return to the same window.

That was enough magic for him.



The Distance Between Their Hands

The most difficult thing about loving through the Faraway Realm was that it could make distance look smaller than it really was.

Inside the Realm, Abdulrahim and Sun'dus could sit only a few steps apart.

They could see every change in each other's faces. They could hear every laugh. They could watch each other grow tired. They could speak until sunrise in one kingdom and deep night in the other.

Then one of them would reach forward.
And the truth returned.
There was no touch.
No warmth.
No hand to hold.
Only light.

At first, they made jokes about it.
"If you were really here," Abdulrahim said once, "you would probably be tired of me by now."
Sun'dus smiled. "Probably."
"That was too fast."
"You asked."
"You were supposed to say never."
"Then ask someone who lies."

He laughed.

But there were other nights when the distance did not feel funny.

There were nights when Sun'dus cried and Abdulrahim could do nothing except remain visible in the mirror.

He wanted to sit beside her.

He wanted to hold her hand and let silence do what words could not.

Instead, his hand passed through the place where hers appeared.

There were nights when Abdulrahim felt tired of his own thoughts and wished Sun'dus could simply be in the same room.

He imagined resting his head near her, saying nothing, knowing she was there.

The Realm gave them almost everything except the one thing their hearts began to ask for most.

Presence.

Real presence.

The distance also created problems that would have been easier face to face.

A short message could sound cold when it was not meant to be.

A delayed reply could feel like rejection.

A tired voice could sound angry.

Silence could become dangerous when Abdulrahim's mind began filling it with guesses.

He knew he overthought.

Knowing did not always stop him.

One evening, Sun'dus disappeared from the Realm longer than expected.

There was no terrible reason. Her life in Zahraan had simply become busy.

But Abdulrahim spent hours building explanations that had no proof.

When she finally opened the mirror, he was already upset.

"Where were you?" he asked.

Sun'dus frowned. "I was busy."

"You could have said something."

"I am saying it now."

"After disappearing."

"Abdulrahim, I did not disappear."

The argument grew from almost nothing.

Soon, neither was speaking about the original problem.

Abdulrahim was talking about feeling ignored.

Sun'dus was talking about feeling controlled.

He became stubborn.

She became quieter.

That quietness made him push harder.

His pushing made her pull farther away.
The golden thread between their mirrors tightened
like a string caught in the wind.
Then Sun'dus said, "I need space."
Those words were difficult for Abdulrahim.
Space felt too much like loss.
"So you are leaving?"
"I said I need space."
"That means leaving."
"No. It means I am upset and I do not want to make it
worse."
He should have listened.
Instead, he kept talking.
The mirror closed.
Abdulrahim stared at his reflection.
His anger lasted only a few minutes.
Regret arrived immediately after.
That became a pattern they would have to learn how
to break.
He could start a fight because he was afraid of
distance.
Then the fight created the very distance he feared.
Sun'dus could go quiet because she wanted peace.
Then her silence could make Abdulrahim feel even
more afraid.
Neither was trying to hurt the other.

They simply had different ways of protecting themselves when emotions became too much.

The next day, Abdulrahim sent a message through the mirror.

I am sorry.

A little later he sent another.

I should have listened.

Then another.

I miss you.

Hours passed.

Finally, the silver mark glowed.

Sun'dus opened the window.

She still looked upset.

Abdulrahim did not begin with excuses.

"I was wrong," he said.

Sun'dus stayed quiet.

"I got scared because I missed you. Then I turned that fear into an argument. You did not deserve that."

Her face softened only a little.

"I don't like feeling like I have to explain every minute."

"I know."

"And when I say I need space, I need you to hear me."

He nodded.

"I will try."

"Not just say it."

"I know."

They talked for a long time.

By the end, they were not fully happy, but they understood each other better.

That mattered.

The distance between their hands could not be removed yet.

The distance between their hearts could still be reduced by honesty.

They began learning that love was not only the beautiful feeling that brought them back to the mirror every night.

It was also the work of understanding how not to turn fear into damage.

There were good ways to miss someone and bad ways. Abdulrahim had to learn the difference.

A good kind of missing made him send Sun'dus a message telling her he hoped her day was going well.

A bad kind made him ask questions with suspicion hidden inside them.

A good kind made him look forward to the evening.

A bad kind made him treat every delay like proof that something had changed.

Sun'dus learned something too. When she became hurt, disappearing without explanation might protect her from an argument for a few hours, but it often made the next conversation harder.

They started creating small habits that helped.
If Sun'dus needed space, she tried to say it clearly.
If Abdulrahim felt jealous or afraid, he tried to ask
instead of accuse.

Neither was perfect at these rules. They broke them.
They apologized. They tried again.

One night, after a disagreement had finally ended,
Abdulrahim leaned his forehead against the mirror.

Sun'dus did the same from the other side.

Their faces were close enough to make the distance
feel cruel.

"I hate this glass sometimes," he said.

"Me too."

"If you were here, I think half our fights would end with
a hug."

"And the other half?"

"You would walk away dramatically."

Sun'dus laughed. "Correct."

He smiled.

Then he became serious.

"I am sorry I make distance harder than it already is."

Sun'dus looked at him. "Just keep learning."

"I am trying."

"I know."

Their foreheads remained against opposite sides of
the glass.

They felt nothing physical.

Still, the moment brought peace.

Distance was not only a problem to survive. It was teaching them what they would one day need when the mirrors were gone: trust, patience, and the ability to say what hurt without making love itself the enemy.



The Nights the Books Went Silent

The first serious separation did not begin with a great tragedy.

Most painful distances do not.

It began with disappointment, pride, tired words, and two people who cared about each other but did not yet know how to handle every difficult feeling.

After one argument, their private pages went silent and the seeing mirror stayed dark for several days.

Abdulrahim told himself he was done.

Sun'dus told herself she needed peace.

The Faraway Realm continued without them.

People still moved through its public courts. Mirrors still opened. Water still ran beneath the glass bridges. Flowers still turned toward moonlight.

Their private book pages remained blank. The mirror between Asterra and Zahraan remained dark.

Abdulrahim hated how much that silence affected him.

He tried to fill his time.

He walked through Asterra.

He studied.

He made plans.

He told himself that a person should be able to live a full life without waiting for one particular mirror to shine.

He was right.

But being right did not stop him from checking.

Every evening, he passed the closed magic book and the covered seeing mirror and wondered whether Sun'dus had written anything on her side.

Some nights he almost touched the glass.

Then pride stopped him.

Other nights he became angry with himself for caring so much.

In Zahraan, Sun'dus was living her own days.

She did not stop existing because Abdulrahim was hurt.

She had her own responsibilities, thoughts, family, dreams, and emotions. She could love him and still become tired of arguments. She could miss him and still believe a little distance was needed.

That truth was difficult for Abdulrahim to accept at first.

He wanted love to mean that neither of them would ever need to step away.

Real love taught him something else.

Sometimes two people could care deeply and still fail each other for a while.

Sometimes returning required more than missing each other.

It required growth.

After several days, Abdulrahim opened the mirror. The Rose Mirror Court appeared.

Empty.

He sat anyway.

The golden thread that had once shone between their mirrors was faint now, almost invisible.

Abdulrahim looked at it and felt ashamed of how often he had treated the thread like proof that everything would always repair itself.

Nothing repaired itself.

People repaired things.

They had to choose it.

He began speaking even though Sun'dus was not there.

"I am sorry," he said to the empty seat.

The Realm did not answer.

"I don't know if you can hear this."

Still nothing.

"I keep thinking love means I should never feel far from you. Maybe that is part of why I make things worse. I get scared the second something changes."

The silver flowers moved in a small wind.

"I don't want to keep hurting you because I am afraid of losing you."

He waited.

No doorway opened.

So he went home.

The next night he returned.

Still empty.

The night after that, he did the same.

On the fourth night, Sun'dus appeared.

She did not smile.

Abdulrahim did not rush toward her.

They looked at each other across the stream.

"I heard you," she said.

He nodded.

"All of it?"

"Enough."

He swallowed.

"I meant it."

"I know."

There was a long silence.

Then Sun'dus sat down.

Abdulrahim sat too.

They did not fix everything in five minutes.

They talked slowly.

They disagreed about some memories.

They admitted when they had misunderstood each other.

Abdulrahim apologized more than once.

Sun'dus explained things she had kept inside because she had not wanted another argument.

The Realm brightened little by little.

By the end of the night, the thread between them was visible again.

Not because magic had decided to save them.

Because they had decided to speak honestly.

That was only one separation.

There would be others.

Some lasted days.

Some lasted much longer.

There were seasons when their seeing mirror remained closed for months. Once, so much time passed that Abdulrahim almost stopped believing they would find their way back at all.

But the novel of their love would not be built by listing every breakup like marks on a wall.

What mattered was the pattern they slowly began to understand.

They could leave in anger.

They could become strangers for a while.

They could try to live as if the story had ended.

Then one message, one apology, one honest conversation could open the window again.

And strangely, after all the pain of finding the way back, ordinary closeness often returned faster than expected.

By the next day, they might be laughing.

By the next night, one might be asking whether the other had eaten.

Their love had a memory of its own.

It remembered how to be home.

That did not mean the separations were good.

It meant they kept being given another chance to learn from them.

During the longest silences, the Faraway Realm sometimes sent old memories to the surface of the seeing mirror. It did not do this to force people back together. The Realm simply stored what had happened inside it.

One night Abdulrahim saw a memory of Sun'dus laughing in the Rose Mirror Court. Another showed the first time she had fallen asleep while connected to him. Another showed the moment he had said I love you and immediately learned that love did not always receive the answer it wanted.

He almost covered the mirror again.
Instead he watched.

What hurt was not only missing Sun'dus. He missed the version of himself that had existed with her: more hopeful, more motivated, more willing to imagine a future larger than the present.

That frightened him.

He did not want his whole purpose to depend on one person.

So during the separation, Abdulrahim forced himself to build purpose that belonged to him too. He studied. He planned. He worked on his own character. He thought about the man he wanted to become whether or not the mirror ever opened again.

This mattered later.

When love returned, he did not want to bring Sun'dus a heart that expected her to carry his entire life.

He wanted to bring her a full life that had room for hers.

In Zahraan, Sun'dus was growing too, though Abdulrahim could not see it.

When they finally spoke again, they did not return as exactly the same two people who had left.

That was why the reunion could become more than repeating the past.

The closed mirrors had hurt them.

They had also forced both of them to stand on their own feet.



The Road Back to Each Other

There was a season when their private book stayed silent and the seeing mirror between Asterra and Zahraan remained dark so long that dust gathered on Abdulrahim's side of the frame.

At first, he checked it every day.
Then every few days.
Then less often.

He told himself he was moving on.
In some ways, he was.

He became busier. He focused on his own future. He studied more seriously. He spent less time waiting for the Realm to change his mood.

That growth was good for him.
Love should not turn a person's whole life into a waiting room.

But even while Abdulrahim grew, Sun'dus remained somewhere inside the way he thought about the future.

He tried to imagine a life in which she was only a memory.
The picture never felt complete.
He did not understand why.

He stopped trying to give the feeling a perfect explanation.

He simply loved her.
That was the truth.
Not a spell.
Not destiny forcing him.
Not a punishment.

A truth he carried whether he liked it or not.

One evening, after a long time away from the
Faraway Realm, Abdulrahim uncovered the seeing
mirror.

He only wanted to look.

That was what he told himself.
The glass was dark.

He touched it.

A small silver light appeared.

Then a message.

His name.

Abdulrahim froze.

One word should not have been able to change a
room.

It did.

He opened the seeing mirror.

The Rose Mirror Court appeared after a slow wave of
light.

Sun'dus stood on the other side.
For a moment, neither moved.

They had spoken a thousand times before, yet suddenly they looked like strangers who knew too much about each other.

"Hi," Sun'dus said.

Abdulrahim's throat felt tight.

"Hi."

That was all.

No dramatic speech.

No music.

Just two people standing inside a magical garden, unsure how to begin again.

Sun'dus looked at the stream.

"You look different."

"Good different or bad different?"

The smallest smile appeared.

"Still you."

That helped.

They began carefully.

How have you been?

How are your studies?

How is your family?

How is Asterra?

How is Zahraan?

The questions sounded formal at first. Then Abdulrahim said something stupid. Sun'dus laughed.

The sound broke the wall between them.
Within an hour, their voices had changed.
They were no longer two distant people trying to
remember how to speak.

They were Abdulrahim and Sun'dus again.
That surprised both of them.

It almost felt unfair that months of silence could lose
their power so quickly.

"This is strange," Abdulrahim said.

"What?"

"Yesterday I thought I had forgotten how to talk to you."

"And today?"

"Today you are already annoying me again."

Sun'dus smiled. "Good. I was worried."

The next day felt even more normal.

By the next night, Abdulrahim was apologizing for
old things he had finally learned to understand better.
Some apologies were about jealousy.

Some were about arguments he had started.

Some were about words said while hurt.

Some were about disappearing when he should have
stayed and listened.

He did not expect an apology to erase the past.

He wanted Sun'dus to know that he could see his part
in it.

She listened.

Sometimes she accepted quickly.

Sometimes she told him that saying sorry was not enough if the same problem kept returning.

He knew she was right.

Their love began again, but not exactly as before. Something had changed.

The distance had taught them what losing daily closeness felt like.

They became less interested in winning every argument.

They became more interested in not destroying peace over small things.

They were not perfect at it.

But they were trying with more maturity than before.

The road back to each other had been long.

Once they reached it, they did not want to walk away so easily again.

The first week after they found their way back was almost strange in its normality. Abdulrahim had expected every conversation to be serious, full of explanations and careful steps. Instead, after the first difficult talks, Sun'dus began sending him small things again.

A picture of the sky.

A message telling him to eat.

A complaint about something ordinary.

A joke.

The normal things were what made the return feel real.

One afternoon, Abdulrahim received a message from her that simply said, You are annoying.

He stared at it and smiled like he had been given a gift.

He answered, Finally. We are back.

Sun'dus sent a laughing mark through the mirror.

That evening, they talked until late. There were moments when old pain came near the surface, but neither tried to drag the other back into every detail. They spoke about what mattered now: what they had learned, what needed to change, and what they wanted to protect.

Abdulrahim admitted that he often apologized because he hated distance more than he hated being wrong.

"That is not always good," Sun'dus told him.

"I know."

"Sometimes you say sorry just to end the fight."

"Also true."

"Then later you repeat the same thing."

Abdulrahim winced. "Very true."

Sun'dus looked at him. "I don't need a hundred apologies. I need you to understand me."

That sentence stayed with him.

He began trying to make his apologies smaller and his changes bigger.

It was not instant. Some habits returned. Some fears returned. But now he noticed them sooner.

Sun'dus also began saying more when she was hurt instead of expecting Abdulrahim to understand every silence.

Their return became less about going back to the old relationship and more about building a better version of it.

The Realm reflected that change. The Rose Mirror Court looked the same, but the stream was calmer. The golden thread no longer flashed wildly with every strong feeling. It held a quieter light.

Abdulrahim liked it that way.

Their love had once felt like something bright and dangerous.

Now it was beginning to feel steady.



Before We Sleep

The promise was never written on paper.

It was never written as a grand rule inside their magic books or announced in the public courts of the Faraway Realm.

It became real through repetition.

Do not let every fight become a goodbye.

Do not let anger decide the future.

Whenever possible, do not go to sleep carrying a war between you.

Abdulrahim and Sun'dus still argued.

Some days they were peaceful from morning until night.

Other days one small thing could become an hour of stubbornness.

Abdulrahim remained emotional. He remained protective, romantic, playful, jealous sometimes, and far too good at overthinking.

Sun'dus remained capable of becoming very quiet when upset. She could need space at the exact moment Abdulrahim wanted to solve everything immediately.

But the difference was that neither wanted breaking up to become the answer anymore.

One night, they had a terrible argument.

Abdulrahim could not even remember later how it began.

By the middle of it, he had said something too sharply.

Sun'dus stopped speaking.

The golden thread between their mirrors dimmed.
"Say something," Abdulrahim said.
She looked away.

"Sun'dus."

"I don't want to talk right now."

His first instinct was to keep pushing.

He felt the old fear rise inside him.

If she went silent, his mind would fill the silence.

Then he remembered all the times that fear had made things worse.

He took a breath.

"Okay."

Sun'dus looked at him, surprised.

"Okay?"

"You said you need space. I am listening."

She remained quiet.

Abdulrahim sat on his stone seat.

He did not close the mirror.

He simply waited.

Minutes passed.

The Realm grew darker.

Sun'dus sat too.

Neither spoke.

The silence was uncomfortable, but it was not empty.
They were both still there.

Eventually Abdulrahim said softly, "I am sorry for the way I spoke."

Sun'dus looked down.

"I know I started this."

Still nothing.

"I am not asking you to stop being upset. I just want you to know I regret it."

The silver flowers near her mirror opened one by one.

A long time later, Sun'dus spoke.

"You make me tired sometimes."

Abdulrahim laughed once, quietly. "I know."

"Too much thinking."

"I know."

"Too much talking when you should stop talking."

"That one is also true."

She almost smiled.

"And then you apologize until I get tired of being angry."

"That is strategy."

Sun'dus finally laughed.

The argument did not disappear magically.

They still had to talk about it.

But by the time the moon in the Realm moved toward morning, the fight had ended.

"Goodnight, Hayati," Abdulrahim said.

Sun'dus looked at him.

"Goodnight, Hayati."

The mirror closed.

Abdulrahim lay down in Asterra feeling tired but peaceful.

This was what their relationship had become.
Not a love without conflict.

A love learning how to survive conflict without turning every wound into an ending.

They still had difficult days.

They still misunderstood each other.

But now, when the mirrors shook, they tried to repair the glass instead of breaking it.

That change was quiet.

It was also one of the strongest signs that they were growing.

The promise not to let every argument become a goodbye changed their nights.

It did not mean they forced themselves to solve every problem before sleep. Some problems were too large for that. Sometimes one of them was too tired. Sometimes Sun'dus needed more time than Abdulrahim wanted to give.

But even then, they tried to leave a small bridge open.

"We are still upset," Sun'dus might say.

"I know."

"We will talk tomorrow."

"Okay."

"And don't start imagining ten terrible things before morning."

Abdulrahim would sigh. "I will imagine only five."

"Abdulrahim."

"Fine. Two."

Sometimes that small joke was enough to remind both of them that the relationship was larger than the argument.

They also created a habit of saying goodnight even when the conversation had been difficult. Not always warmly. Not always with long messages. But the words mattered.

Goodnight meant: I am not disappearing.

Goodnight meant: we are still us, even if today was hard.

Goodnight meant: tomorrow is allowed to be better.

One evening, after another argument Abdulrahim had mostly caused, Sun'dus looked exhausted.

"I don't understand why you make a problem when there isn't one," she said.

He had no good defense.

"Sometimes I see danger before there is danger," he admitted.

"Then stop fighting ghosts."

The sentence was so accurate that he laughed despite himself.

Sun'dus tried to stay angry. She failed.

"Do not laugh."

"You called my thoughts ghosts."

"Because they are."

He became serious again. "I will work on it."
She nodded.

That was what their love looked like now.
Not perfect peace.
Repair.
Again and again.



The Girl Behind the Crown

The first thing Abdulrahim had seen was beauty.

The second thing he had learned was that Sun'dus was a princess.

For a commoner from Asterra, that should have made the whole story feel impossible. Zahraan had a palace, royal duties, old customs, and a future that had been planned around Sun'dus long before a blank memory book carried Abdulrahim into her life.

But the Faraway Realm had done something strange from the beginning: it had allowed him to know Sun'dus before he learned how heavy her title was.

To him, the crown was never the most important thing about her.

The girl behind it was.

There was another reason Abdulrahim stopped being impressed by the crown. Sun'dus never used it to make herself larger inside their private world. In the Faraway Realm, she did not ask for servants, guards, or special paths. She sat beside him on the same low stone walls as everyone else. She complained when she was tired. She laughed at simple things. She cared when someone in her family was unwell. She could spend a long time

choosing a gift because she wanted the person receiving it to feel remembered.

One night she placed a memory in his book without warning. It showed no royal ceremony. She was simply sitting with family, listening more than speaking, passing food across a table and smiling when someone else laughed. The memory lasted less than a minute. Abdulrahim watched it twice.

When she called through the mirror later, she asked, "Why did you watch that one again? Nothing happened." "Something happened."

"What?"

"You were yourself."

Sun'dus became quiet.

That was the kind of memory he treasured most. Not the ones that proved she was a princess, but the ones that let him know the woman he hoped one day to call his wife.

Silver light touched her face. Roses opened behind her. Stars sometimes appeared in the stream when she laughed. The seeing mirror gave every meeting a beauty ordinary rooms did not have.

But Abdulrahim's love for her was no longer about the magic.

It was about the person behind it.

He had learned the difference slowly.

At first, he had been drawn to her face. He had opened her memory book after the public gathering and felt that strange first pull toward the kind of woman he had always imagined.

Later, he began noticing the things beauty could not explain.

The way Sun'dus listened without making every conversation about herself.

The way she remembered small things he had forgotten he ever told her.

The way she checked on him when his mood changed.

The way she could care about his future with more seriousness than he sometimes gave it himself.

The way she trusted him.

The way she wanted a peaceful life, not only romantic words.

Sun'dus had dreams of her own beyond the palace walls.

She wanted to finish her studies. She wanted success. She wanted comfort. She wanted to live without feeling that every desire had to be measured against what she could afford. She liked beautiful things, travel, good food, gifts, quiet family time, attention, care, and the feeling of being understood.

Abdulrahim loved hearing her talk about those things.

Some men might have heard a dream of comfort and thought only about money.

Abdulrahim heard responsibility.

If he wanted to be part of her future, he did not want to arrive there with only promises.

He wanted to build.

He wanted to become capable.

He wanted to protect without controlling, provide without making her feel owned, and support her dreams without turning them into his decisions.

That was harder than saying I love you.

One evening, Sun'dus asked, "Why are you quiet?"

Abdulrahim was sitting beside the stream, looking at the lights of Zahraan in the mirror behind her.

"Thinking."

"That is usually dangerous."

He smiled. "About the future."

Sun'dus became interested. "What future?"

"Ours."

"What about it?"

Abdulrahim looked at her.

"I don't want to spend years telling you I will give you a good life and then arrive with nothing except words."

Sun'dus said nothing.

"I want to finish what I need to finish. I want to work. I want to be successful. I want you to feel safe with me."

Her expression softened.

"You don't have to become perfect."

"Good, because that plan was already failing."

She laughed.

Then he continued more seriously.

"But I do want to become ready."

Sun'dus looked toward the stream.

"Me too."

That answer meant a lot to him.

Their future was not Abdulrahim rescuing Sun'dus from a tower.

She was not waiting helplessly for him.

They were both growing toward the same life from different kingdoms.

That made the story better.

It also made the waiting more meaningful.

Abdulrahim began seeing Sun'dus not only as the girl he missed, but as the woman he hoped to marry.

He imagined her making decisions beside him.

He imagined her having her own ambitions.

He imagined supporting her when she became tired.

He imagined arguments they had not had yet, bills they had not paid yet, places they had not traveled yet, children who did not exist yet, and ordinary evenings in a home that had not been built.

He knew dreams could change.

He knew life could become harder than any picture in a mirror.

Still, the future gave him purpose.
Sun'dus did that too.

She made him want to become a better version of himself not because she demanded perfection, but because he cared about the life they might share.

One night, Abdulrahim told her, "You make me take my own life more seriously."

Sun'dus looked surprised.

"Why?"

"Because I want to bring something good into yours."

She stayed quiet for a moment.

"Then do it for yourself too."

He smiled.

"See? This is what I mean."

"What?"

"You care about my life more than I do sometimes."

"Someone has to."

He laughed, but his eyes became warm.
The Faraway Realm was beautiful.

Sun'dus was more important than the Realm.
Magic had introduced them.

Care was what kept them close.

Abdulrahim also loved the parts of Sun'dus that were harder to explain.

The way she sometimes said "nothing" when something clearly mattered.

The way a short answer could hide a large feeling.

The way she could care deeply without always making a show of it.

He learned that if her voice became too calm during an argument, he should listen more carefully, not less. He learned that when she remembered a tiny detail from weeks before, it was one of her ways of showing care. He learned that when she stayed on the mirror after saying she was tired, it often meant she did not want the conversation to end yet.

Once, Sun'dus asked him, "Why do you always look at me like you are trying to solve something?"

Abdulrahim smiled. "Because you are difficult to read."

"Maybe you should stop trying."

"Impossible."

"Why?"

"Because I want to know the real answer, not only the first one."

Sun'dus looked away, but not before he saw the small smile.

He did not pretend he always understood her. Sometimes he was completely wrong. That became important too.

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Loving someone did not mean turning them into a puzzle you could finish. Sun'dus was allowed to surprise him, change her mind, have feelings he did not understand, and keep parts of herself private until she wanted to share them.

Abdulrahim's job was not to know everything.

It was to keep paying attention.

That difference made his love gentler.

He still loved her eyes, her smile, her voice, and the softness in her face. But those were no longer the main reason he imagined a life with her.

He imagined it because of how she cared.

Because she had become the person who could make him laugh when he was angry with the world.

Because she could remind him of his own future when he became careless with it.

Because she wanted family, faith, comfort, success, and peace.

Because when he thought of home, her presence belonged there.

Sometimes Abdulrahim worried about the difference between their worlds. He came from ordinary streets. She came from palace halls. He wanted to build his future with work, study, and patience, not with a title he had inherited.

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Sun'dus never treated that difference as a reason for him to become smaller. She cared more about what kind of man he was becoming.

That changed the way he understood love.

He did not want to reach a princess because she wore a crown. He wanted to become a husband worthy of the woman who had trusted him with the pages she kept hidden from the rest of the world.



The Gate They Chose to Wait For

Deep inside the Faraway Realm stood one place Abdulrahim and Sun'dus had spoken about for years but never used.

The True Gate.

Unlike the mirrors, the Gate did not send only light and voice across distance.

It could carry a real person from one kingdom to another, not as light, not as a reflection, but in the body.

Very few people used it. The magic was old, expensive, and difficult to open. But it existed.

The first time Abdulrahim and Sun'dus stood before it together, the idea felt almost too powerful.

The Gate was a tall arch of pale stone beside a black lake. Its surface looked like clear water standing upright. Through it, a traveler could see a place far away as if looking through an open door.

Abdulrahim saw a quiet courtyard in Zahraan.

Sun'dus saw a mountain road in Asterra.

For the first time, the distance between their kingdoms looked like something that could be crossed. Abdulrahim moved closer.

So did Sun'dus.

The golden thread between them brightened.

They could have tried to find a way.

They could have planned a secret meeting.

They could have told themselves that after so many years of seeing each other only through magic, one touch would do no harm.

Instead, they stood still.

Their faith mattered to both of them.

They did not want their first real meeting to begin with hiding.

They did not want their first embrace to come with guilt.

They had spoken about marriage so many times that the idea was no longer a distant joke. They wanted to meet when they could finally stand together as husband and wife.

That choice was not easy.

It was especially difficult because the Gate made the possibility visible.

Abdulrahim imagined stepping through.

He imagined Sun'dus becoming solid in front of him.

He imagined what her hand would feel like.

Then he looked at her through the light.

"We wait," he said.

Sun'dus nodded.

"We wait."

There was no rule from the Realm forcing them.

No magical wall pushed them apart.

This was their decision.

That made it stronger.

They agreed that they would finish their studies first.

Then, when the time was right, families would know. The marriage would be made properly. The first time Abdulrahim traveled to Sun'dus would not be to meet a secret girlfriend.

It would be to meet his wife.

The idea made them both emotional.

"Do you know how long that feels?" Abdulrahim asked.

"Very long."

"Five more years can feel like fifty."

Sun'dus smiled a little. "Then we need more patience."

"I don't like patience."

"I know."

"I like you."

"That is why you need patience."

He laughed even though his chest hurt.

They left the True Gate closed.

After that night, the Gate became part of their story in a new way.

It was no longer only a door they could not use. It became a promise.

Whenever distance became painful, Abdulrahim thought of it.

Whenever Sun'dus wished the years would move faster, she thought of it too.

The Gate was waiting.

So were they.

There were nights when Abdulrahim admitted how difficult it felt.

"I want to hug you," he said once.

Sun'dus became quiet.

"Me too."

"I want to know what it feels like when you are actually beside me."

"Me too."

He rested his palm against his mirror.

Sun'dus placed hers against the same point from the other side.

Their hands appeared to touch.

They felt nothing.

"One day," Abdulrahim whispered.

"Insha'Allah," Sun'dus replied.

The golden thread between their hearts glowed gently.

They did not need the Realm to promise that day would come.

They needed faith, effort, patience, and time.

And so they chose to wait.

After they chose to leave the True Gate closed, the decision became part of their daily love.

There were moments when it was easy.
Other moments were much harder.

A beautiful day in one kingdom could make Abdulrahim wish Sun'dus were beside him to see it. A difficult day could make the wish even stronger. Sometimes he wanted nothing dramatic. He wanted to sit near her in silence. He wanted to hand her something instead of sending its memory through light. He wanted to know what ordinary closeness felt like.

Sun'dus understood because she felt the same.

One evening they returned to the True Gate and sat on the steps without opening it.

"Do you think we are crazy?" Abdulrahim asked.

"For what?"

"Waiting this long."

Sun'dus thought for a moment. "Maybe a little."

He laughed.

Then she continued, "But I want the day we meet to be right."

"Me too."

"I don't want our first hug to be something we hide and feel guilty about later."

Abdulrahim looked at the dark surface of the Gate.

"Neither do I."

He imagined that first hug again. He had imagined it many times. In every version he held her too tightly.

"You know I am going to cry," he said.

Sun'dus smiled. "I know."

"And you?"

"Maybe."

"You will."

"We will see."

They both knew the truth.

The day would carry too many years inside it for either of them to remain calm.

They stood and left the Gate closed.

Waiting was difficult.

But choosing together made it feel like devotion instead of punishment.



Prayers Under One Moon

Waiting became easier when it had a purpose.
It never became easy.

There were still nights when Abdulrahim hated the mirror.

He hated that it could show him Sun'dus's eyes perfectly but could not let him wipe away a tear.

He hated that he could hear her voice in the middle of the night but could not walk across a room and sit beside her.

He hated that the True Gate existed and still remained closed by their own choice.

But there was also peace in that choice.

They were not simply trapped by distance.

They were protecting the kind of beginning they wanted.

Faith became part of how they survived the years.

Sometimes they prayed separately in their own kingdoms, knowing the other was asking for the same future.

Make it easier for us.

Give us patience.

Protect what is good between us.

Help us finish what we need to finish.

Unite us in a halal way.
Those prayers did not make every problem disappear.
They did not stop arguments.
They did not make time move faster.
But they gave the waiting meaning beyond emotion.
One night, the Faraway Realm opened beneath a thin
crescent moon.

Abdulrahim and Sun'dus walked to a quiet hill where
both of their kingdom skies could be seen in the mirrors
around them.

Asterra's mountains appeared on one side.
Zahraan's white rooftops appeared on the other.
The same crescent hung above both.

"Do you ever think about how strange this is?"
Abdulrahim asked.

"What?"

"That we have never stood in the same real place."
Sun'dus nodded.

"Sometimes."

"And still you know things about me people near me
don't know."

"That is because you never stop talking."
He gave her a look.
She smiled.
Then her expression became softer.

"I think about the day we meet."

Abdulrahim looked at her quickly.

"Every day?"

"Not every minute."

"That is not what I asked."

She laughed. "A lot."

He looked at the crescent.

"Me too."

They sat in silence.

Then Abdulrahim said quietly, "May Allah make it easy for us."

"Ameen."

"May He give us patience."

"Ameen."

"And may we reach that day in a good way."

Sun'dus looked at him.

"Ameen."

They did not make a dramatic magical oath.

They did not need one.

Their prayer was enough.

After that night, whenever the distance felt too large, Abdulrahim imagined the same crescent above Zahraan.

Whenever Sun'dus became tired of waiting, she could look at the moon and know that Asterra was under it too.

It was a simple thing.

That was why it mattered.

The moon belonged to neither kingdom.
It reached both without choosing sides.
So did prayer.
Faith also gave them a language for the things they
could not control.
They could work hard. They could study. They could
plan. They could try to become better for each other.
But they could not control every year ahead.
So they prayed.
Not only for marriage.
They prayed for protection from the kind of mistakes
that had hurt them before. They prayed for patience
when emotions became heavy. They prayed for success
in their studies and future work. They prayed that the
love between them would become something good, not
something that pulled either of them away from who
they wanted to be.
One night Sun'dus asked, "What if the future is
harder than we think?"
Abdulrahim did not answer with an easy promise.
"Then we will need more patience than we think."
"And if we fight?"
"We will probably fight."
She smiled slightly.
"That is not romantic."
"It is honest."

"And then?"

"Then I will apologize too much."

"Definitely."

"And you will be stubborn."

"Maybe."

"Definitely."

They both laughed.

Then Abdulrahim became serious.

"And we will remember why we waited."

Sun'dus looked at him.

"That part is romantic," she said.

The crescent above them shone softly.

They made their dua, each in their own heart, and let the quiet hold what words could not.



The House Beyond Tomorrow

The Faraway Realm had one mirror that did not show the present.

It was called the Tomorrow Glass.

Most visitors ignored it because it did not predict the future. It did something stranger.

It showed a possible world made from the hopes of the people standing before it.

If two people looked together, the glass gathered the dreams they had spoken aloud and turned them into a living picture.

One evening, Abdulrahim and Sun'dus decided to try it.

At first, the mirror showed only mist.
Then a doorway appeared.
A house stood beyond it.
Not a palace.

Not a castle with golden towers.

A beautiful home filled with warm light - not Zahraan's palace and not the modest streets of Abdulrahim's childhood, but a home that belonged to both of them.

Sun'dus stepped closer.

The mirror showed a wide sitting room, soft curtains moving in the breeze, books on a shelf, flowers near a window, and a table large enough for family.

Abdulrahim smiled.

"You chose the flowers."

"You chose the books."

"That is fair."

The vision changed.

They saw a kitchen full of noise.

They saw travel bags near a doorway.

They saw Sun'dus standing in front of a wardrobe far too large for one person.

Abdulrahim laughed.

"That is definitely your dream."

"You said I should be able to afford anything I want."

"I did not realize the mirror was keeping records."

She smiled proudly.

The vision changed again.

A small child ran across a garden.

Then another.

The details were not clear enough to know faces or names. That made the image sweeter rather than less real.

Abdulrahim and Sun'dus had spoken about having only a few children one day. Enough to fill a home with life, not enough to turn every morning into a war.

"They look troublesome," Abdulrahim said.

"They probably got it from you."

"Impossible."

"Very possible."

The mirror showed more.

A comfortable life.

Trips to places they had once only seen in memory pages.

Sun'dus buying something beautiful without worrying whether she could afford it.

Abdulrahim working hard, then coming home tired and happy that the work meant something.

Quiet family evenings.

Celebrations.

Ordinary mornings.

Arguments too.

The Tomorrow Glass did not create a perfect fantasy.

In one scene, Abdulrahim and Sun'dus were clearly upset with each other in the kitchen.

"Even the dream has fights?" Abdulrahim complained.

Sun'dus laughed. "At least it is realistic."

The next scene showed them sitting together later, calmer.

That felt more important than a life without conflict. The final image was simple.

An older Abdulrahim and an older Sun'dus sat
outside the same home beneath a warm evening sky.
They were not young.

The house behind them had changed with years of
living.

The garden looked full.

Their hands rested beside each other.

This time there was no mirror between them.
Abdulrahim became quiet.

Sun'dus did too.

The vision faded.

"That one," Abdulrahim said softly.

"What?"

"That is the one I want."

Sun'dus looked at him.

"The big house?"

"No."

He smiled.

"The old part."

Her eyes softened.

"Me too."

The Tomorrow Glass went dark.

They knew it had not shown a promise.
Life could change.
Plans could change.

They would have to work for whatever future they reached.

But the mirror had given shape to something they talked about every day.

Not just marriage.

A life.

A rich life in more ways than money.

Comfort.

Success.

Family.

Travel.

Peace.

And years together long enough for youth to become memory.

After they left the Tomorrow Glass, they kept talking about the life it had shown.

The mirror had not created new dreams. It had simply placed their old conversations into rooms they could see. That made those conversations feel more real.

Sun'dus wanted a beautiful home, but not a home that looked impressive and felt cold. She wanted warmth. She wanted comfort. She wanted to be able to buy something she loved without spending the whole day worrying about the cost. She wanted to travel without every trip becoming an impossible plan.

Abdulrahim wanted the same ease for her.

"I want you to enjoy your life," he told her.

"And you?"

"I will enjoy watching you enjoy it."

Sun'dus gave him a look. "That sounds fake."

He laughed. "Fine. I want nice things too."

"Better."

They began building the imaginary home together in conversation.

Sun'dus wanted a beautiful bedroom. Abdulrahim wanted a quiet place to work. They both wanted enough space for family to visit. Sun'dus wanted good light. Abdulrahim wanted a view.

They disagreed about small details before the house even existed.

"No dark walls," Sun'dus said.

"One dark room."

"Why?"

"Because it looks good."

"No."

"You rejected that faster than you rejected me the first time."

Sun'dus stared at him, then burst out laughing. Abdulrahim laughed too.

The future did not have to be spoken about only with serious faces.

That was one of the things he loved most about dreaming with her.

They could speak about children, work, travel, and money, then end up arguing about the color of a room that had not been built.

The dreams gave shape to the years of waiting.

Every exam completed, every skill learned, every good choice made now could become part of that future later.

For Abdulrahim, the house beyond tomorrow slowly became a symbol of more than wealth.

It was the place where distance ended.

Where goodnight would not mean closing a mirror.

Where a difficult day could end with the same person sitting beside him.

Where Sun'dus would no longer be a voice crossing kingdoms.

She would simply be home.



The Years Ahead

The hardest part of waiting was not that time moved slowly.

It was that time kept asking them to trust a future they could not touch yet.

Abdulrahim and Sun'dus knew the plan.

Finish their studies.

Grow.

Prepare.

Let the years do their work.

Then, when the time was right, allow their families and kingdoms to become part of the story and turn the dream into a real marriage.

It sounded simple when spoken in one breath.
Living it was different.

Five years could hold many days.

Many exams.

Many arguments.

Many tired nights.

Many moments when one person needed more reassurance than the other knew how to give.

Many mornings when patience felt less like a beautiful virtue and more like a heavy thing they had to carry.

Still, the waiting had changed.

In the early years, distance often felt like proof that the relationship was fragile.

Now it felt more like a road.

Long, yes.

Sometimes difficult.

But leading somewhere they had chosen together.

Abdulrahim began keeping a small book near his seeing mirror.

He did not write poetry in it.

At least, that was what he told himself.

He wrote plans.

Things he wanted to finish.

Things he wanted to learn.

Ways he wanted to become more responsible.

Money he hoped to save one day.

Places he wanted to take Sun'dus.

Ideas for a home.

Tiny notes from conversations he did not want to forget.

Things Sun'dus liked.

Things that made her happy.

Things he should stop doing because they made arguments worse.

One page said only:

Listen before fixing.

Another said:

Do not turn fear into jealousy.

Another:

She needs peace, not only promises.

He added a final line beneath it.

So do I.

Sun'dus had her own plans in Zahraan.

She wanted success too.

She wanted the freedom of a comfortable life.

She wanted to be able to choose beautiful things without fear, to travel, to enjoy family, to live with ease after years of waiting for so much.

Abdulrahim did not see those dreams as something to hand her like a gift from above.

He saw them as a life they would build together.

Some nights they talked about serious plans.

Other nights they ruined the seriousness within minutes.

"How many rooms?" Sun'dus asked once while they imagined their future home.

"Enough."

"That is not a number."

"Why do we need so many rooms?"

"Because I said so."

"Excellent financial planning."

"You asked what I want."

"I am beginning to regret it."

She smiled. "Too late."

Another night they discussed children.

"A few," Abdulrahim said.

"How many is a few?"

"Not an army."

"Very helpful."

"Two? Three? We will negotiate."

Sun'dus laughed. "You are negotiating children already?"

"I like being prepared."

"You overthink everything."

"Preparation and overthinking are cousins."

Those conversations made the years ahead feel less empty.

They were not simply waiting for a wedding day.

They were slowly learning how to imagine a shared life.

The Faraway Realm became less like a magical escape and more like a bridge between two real futures.

One night, Abdulrahim asked a question that had been living inside him for a long time.

"Are you scared?"

Sun'dus looked at him. "Of what?"

"That we still have so much time ahead."

She thought before answering.

"Sometimes."

"Me too."

"But we have already made it through a lot."

Abdulrahim nodded.

That was true.

They had survived beginnings that did not go as planned.

They had survived rejection without turning it into resentment.

They had survived arguments.

They had survived long silences.

They had survived returning with apologies and trying again.

They had learned that love did not remove every hard thing.

It gave them a reason to face hard things with more care.

"We will make it through the rest," Abdulrahim said.

Sun'dus looked at him across the silver stream.

"Insha'Allah."

The golden thread between them glowed.

Not like a chain.

Like a path.

Time in the Faraway Realm behaved strangely.
Flowers could change seasons in a single night, yet the real years outside the mirrors moved normally.

That difference sometimes frustrated Abdulrahim. In the Realm, he could walk from winter roses to summer trees in minutes. In real life, he could not skip one year of waiting.

So he stopped counting only how much time remained.

He started counting what the time could be used for.

One year could make him more disciplined.

Another could bring him closer to finishing his studies.

Another could teach him how to handle anger better.

Another could help both of them become more ready for family responsibilities.

The years were not empty space between now and marriage.

They were part of preparing for it.

Sun'dus liked that idea.

"So we are not just waiting?" she asked.

"No. We are building while we wait."

"That sounds better."

"It is also harder."

"Of course."

They began encouraging each other more seriously. When one became lazy about something important, the other noticed. When one felt discouraged, the other reminded them of the future they talked about so often.

Abdulrahim sometimes joked that Sun'dus cared about his success more than he did.

She never denied it.

That care touched him.

He did not want to disappoint the person who believed in his future.

At the same time, he learned not to turn every dream into pressure. They were still young. They were allowed to grow slowly.

The road could be serious without becoming joyless. So they kept laughing.

Kept sending pictures.

Kept staying up too late.

Kept reminding each other to eat.

Kept saying Hayati until the word felt less like a nickname and more like a place both of them knew how to return to.



The Wedding Beyond the Gate

There were nights when the future felt so close that the Faraway Realm seemed able to smell it.

On one of those nights, the True Gate changed.

Abdulrahim and Sun'dus had gone there only to sit beside the black lake and talk. They did that sometimes now. The Gate no longer tempted them the way it once had. They had made their choice. They would wait.

But when they arrived, the arch was glowing.
Not brightly.
Softly.

Its clear surface showed no road in Asterra and no courtyard in Zahraan.

Instead it showed a day that did not yet exist.
Sun'dus stopped walking.
Abdulrahim's heart began beating faster.

Through the Gate, they saw Zahraan dressed for a wedding.
White flowers covered an entrance.

Warm lights hung over a courtyard.

People moved in the distance, but their faces were not clear. The vision belonged to the feeling of the day, not to the details of people around it.

At the center of the scene stood a doorway.

Abdulrahim recognized the moment without needing anyone to explain it.

This was after the marriage had been made.

This was the day he would finally come for Sun'dus.

He stepped closer to the Gate.

Sun'dus stood beside him, still made of light because they were inside the Realm.

"Is this real?" she whispered.

"Not yet."

The Gate showed possibility, not prophecy.

They both knew that.

Still, neither could look away.

In the vision, a future Abdulrahim entered the courtyard.

He looked older than the man standing beside the lake now. Not old. Just changed by years, work, waiting, and becoming ready.

His hands were shaking.

Sun'dus saw it too.

"You will cry," she said.

Abdulrahim laughed softly. "I know."

"A lot."

"You will too."

"Maybe."

"Definitely."

The vision moved forward.

The future Abdulrahim waited near the doorway.
Then Sun'dus appeared.

For the first time in all the years of their story, she
was not inside a mirror.
She was not a reflection.
She was not light.
She was real.

The Abdulrahim beside the Gate forgot how to
breathe.

Even though it was only a vision, the sight affected
him more deeply than he expected.

Sun'dus looked at him instead of the Gate.

His eyes had already filled with tears.
"Hayati," she said softly.
He smiled without looking away.
"I have imagined this too many times."

Inside the vision, the future versions of them stood
several steps apart.
Neither moved at first.
That felt true.

After waiting so long, the first moment might be too
large for movement.

Abdulrahim imagined all the nights collapsing into
that silence.

Every good morning.

Every late call through the mirror.

Every picture.

Every apology.

Every fight settled before sleep.

Every month that had once felt impossible.

Every prayer.

Every time they had placed their palms on opposite sides of glass and felt nothing.

All of it would arrive in one room.

The vision paused before the embrace.

The Gate became cloudy.

Abdulrahim frowned.

"Why did it stop?"

Sun'dus smiled through her own tears.

"Maybe that part belongs to us."

The image faded.

The black lake returned.

The Gate stood silent.

Abdulrahim looked at Sun'dus.

"That was cruel."

She laughed. "You wanted the Realm to show you everything?"

"Yes."

"Then what would be left to wait for?"

He looked at the Gate again.

For years, waiting had meant imagining a person he could not touch.

Now the future felt more specific.
One day he would travel to her.
One day the marriage would be real.
One day there would be no need for magic to carry
their voices.

One day he would stand in front of Sun'dus and
discover whether reality felt even stranger than all his
dreams.

He hoped it would.

After the vision disappeared, Abdulrahim and
Sun'dus remained beside the black lake for a long time.
Neither wanted to leave first.

"What do you think the real day will be like?" Sun'dus
asked.

Abdulrahim answered too quickly. "Better."

"You don't know that."

"I do."

"How?"

"Because you will be real."

She became quiet.

Abdulrahim looked at the Gate.

"I think I will have trouble believing it."

"That I am real?"

"That the waiting is over."

He imagined waking that morning and knowing there
would be no goodnight through a mirror later. No silver

light needed to hear her voice. No invisible border between their hands.

"I might keep checking whether you disappear," he said.

Sun'dus smiled. "That would be strange."

"You have no idea how strange ten years of mirrors can make a person."

"You were already strange before the mirrors."

"True."

They laughed.

Then Sun'dus asked, "What will you say first?"
Abdulrahim thought.

He had imagined speeches before. Beautiful sentences. Perfect lines.

Now they all felt false.

"Probably nothing," he said.

"Nothing?"

"I think I will forget every language I know."

Sun'dus laughed so hard the Gate reflected the sound as ripples of light.

"Then I will know it is really you," she said.

That was the kind of future they wanted.
Not perfect.

Theirs.

That vision followed Abdulrahim back to Asterra.
That night, after he closed his magic book and the seeing

mirror faded, he dreamed more clearly than he ever had before.

That night, after Abdulrahim returned to Asterra, he dreamed.

The dream began so quietly that he did not know it was a dream.

There was no Faraway Realm, no magic book, and no seeing mirror.

No mirror.

No silver doorway.

He was standing in Zahraan.

Really standing there.

The air felt warm against his face.

He could hear footsteps on stone. He could smell flowers. He could feel the weight of his own clothes and the nervous shaking in his hands.

For one confused second, Abdulrahim thought he had forgotten something important.

Then he remembered.

This was the day.

The waiting was over.

Their marriage had been made.

He had come to take Sun'dus from her home as his wife.

The thought was so enormous that he almost laughed from fear.

He had spent years imagining what he would say
when he saw her.

Every sentence disappeared.

A door opened.

Sun'dus stepped into view.

Abdulrahim stopped breathing.

She looked like herself.

That was what broke him.

Not like a princess from a painting.

Not like some perfect dream made by magic.

Sun'dus.

The woman from the Rose Mirror Court.

The girl who had once called him stubborn for
refusing to show his face.

The voice that had crossed years of distance.

The person who had heard him at his worst and
stayed close enough to know when he was pretending to
be fine.

The person he had argued with, apologized to,
laughed with, prayed for, and imagined beside him more
times than he could count.

She was standing there.

No glass.

No light-copy.

No Garden.

Real.

Sun'dus covered her mouth with one hand.
Her eyes filled with tears.
Abdulrahim's did too.
He tried to speak.
Nothing came out.
Sun'dus laughed through her tears.
That sound made him laugh too.
For a moment they simply looked at each other.
The years between them seemed to stand in the room
like invisible witnesses.
Then Abdulrahim walked toward her.
Slowly at first.
He reached for her hand.
His fingers touched hers.
He froze.
Warmth.
Real warmth.
The simplest thing in the world felt impossible.
He looked down at their joined hands as if he had
never seen hands before.
Sun'dus was crying openly now.
"You are real," Abdulrahim whispered.
She laughed again. "So are you."
He lifted her hand carefully, then looked at her face.
He had imagined this moment for so long that part of
him still expected to wake.

"Hayati," he said.

Sun'dus answered immediately.

"Hayati."

Abdulrahim leaned forward and kissed her forehead.

Then he wrapped his arms around her.

The first embrace of their lives was not graceful.

It was too tight.

Both were crying.

Both were laughing.

Abdulrahim held her as if years of distance could finally be answered by one impossible hug.

Sun'dus held him back.

For all the beautiful things he had imagined, the truth was simpler.

She fit inside his arms.

That was enough.

Abdulrahim closed his eyes.

He remembered every time his hand had passed through hers in the Faraway Realm.

Every time he had pressed his palm against a mirror.

Every night he had said one day.

The day was here.

He did not want to let go.

"You are holding me too tight," Sun'dus said against him.

Abdulrahim loosened his arms by almost nothing.

"Better?"

"Not really."

"Good."

She laughed.

That laugh finally made the dream feel complete.

The wedding day continued around them, but Abdulrahim noticed very little of it.

He kept looking at Sun'dus as if she might become light again.

He touched her hand more than necessary.

He watched her walk across a room and found the simple fact that she occupied physical space almost unbelievable.

At one point Sun'dus caught him staring.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"You are doing it again."

"I waited almost ten years for this. I am allowed to look."

Her face softened.

"Then look."

He did.

Later, when the noise around them became quieter, Abdulrahim thought of the Faraway Realm.

He wondered whether the Rose Mirror Court still existed without them.

Maybe the fountain still ran.

Maybe the flowers still opened under the moon.
Maybe another pair of distant strangers had found
each other there.

But Abdulrahim did not miss it.

For the first time, magic had become unnecessary.
Sun'dus was beside him.

The story had crossed into real life.

Then the room began to fade.

Abdulrahim tightened his hand around hers.

"No," he whispered.

Sun'dus looked at him with calm eyes.

"What?"

The walls disappeared into moonlight.

"Not yet."

Her hand became light.

"Hayati?"

Abdulrahim woke.

He was in Asterra.

His room was dark.

The seeing mirror stood across from him.

His hand was empty.

For several seconds he could not move.

Then the silver mark on the mirror began to glow.

Sun'dus was calling.

Abdulrahim laughed and wiped his eyes.

Of course she was.

He opened the mirror.

The dream gave Abdulrahim more than the first hug. It gave him a few quiet moments afterward that stayed with him even after he woke.

He remembered sitting beside Sun'dus and realizing how ordinary she looked when magic was removed.

No silver glow around her.

No floating roses.

No stars moving through a mirror.

Just the woman he loved, close enough that he could hear her breathing without any spell carrying the sound.

That ordinary reality felt more beautiful than every enchanted place in the Faraway Realm.

In the dream, Sun'dus noticed him staring again.

"You are still doing it."

"I told you. I waited a long time."

"And now?"

"Now I am trying to understand how you were ever only light."

She reached for his hand.

The simple movement almost made him cry again.

"Get used to it," she said.

"Never."

"You will."

"I don't want to."

He wanted the wonder to stay. Not the distance.
Never the distance. But the gratitude.

He wanted to remember that there had once been
years when holding her hand was impossible.

He wanted that memory to make him careful with
ordinary love.

The dream did not show riches or castles that day.
It showed hands.

A forehead kiss.

Tears.

A hug.

Two people sitting beside each other.

That was enough to make waking painful and hopeful
at the same time.



Until the Gate Opens

The next time Sun'dus appeared in the seeing mirror, she looked sleepy.

"Why are you smiling like that?" she asked.

Abdulrahim sat closer.

"I saw you."

"You are seeing me now."

"No. I mean really saw you."

She understood after a moment.

"A dream?"

He nodded.

"The wedding?"

"Yes."

Sun'dus smiled. "And?"

Abdulrahim looked at her for a long moment.

"It was worth the wait."

"You say that now. You are still dreaming."

"I woke up."

"Exactly. Ask me after the real one."

He laughed.

The Faraway Realm opened around them.

They moved from the mirror into the Rose Mirror Court, the place that had watched so much of their story.

The stream still crossed between them.

The two stone seats remained where they had always been.

The roses had changed with the seasons, but the court still felt like theirs.

Abdulrahim looked around and thought about how much had happened without either of them ever standing physically beside the other.

They had met here as strangers from distant kingdoms.

He had been attracted to her before he knew her heart.

Then he had learned her voice.

Her care.

Her stubbornness.

Her softness.

Her dreams.

He had confessed too soon.

She had said she was not ready.

He had walked away, then come back because he cared about the friendship more than his pride.

Somewhere after that, without a perfect date or announcement, friendship had become love.

They had called each other Hayati.
They had fought.

They had separated more than once.
They had spent months apart.

They had apologized.

They had returned.

They had learned that loving someone deeply did not mean knowing how to love them perfectly.

They had learned to talk after anger.

They had learned not to make every hard day an ending.

They had learned that a relationship could be peaceful without being free of arguments.

They had learned that sometimes the strongest thing they could say before sleep was still, "I am here."

The True Gate remained closed.

Their studies were not finished yet.

Their families had not all become part of the story yet.

There were years ahead.

There would be tests neither could predict.
Abdulrahim knew that.

He no longer wanted a fairytale that pretended love removed every difficulty.

He wanted the kind that admitted the road could be hard and still believed the journey was worth making.
Sun'dus sat across from him.

"You are quiet again," she said.

"Thinking."

"Dangerous."

"I know."

She smiled.

Abdulrahim rested his hands on his knees.

"We have been through a lot."

Sun'dus nodded.

"Too much sometimes."

"And we are still here."

"We are."

"So I think we can make it through what is ahead too."

She looked at him carefully.

Abdulrahim continued.

"Not because everything will be easy. Not because we will never fight. Not because the Realm says we are meant to be together no matter what."

The golden thread between them glowed softly.

"Because we keep choosing to fix things. Because I love you. Because you love me. Because now we both know what we want."

Sun'dus's eyes softened.

"And what do we want?"

Abdulrahim smiled.

"To finish our studies."

"Good."

"To succeed."

"Good."

"To get married."

"Very good."

"To have a beautiful home."

She smiled wider.

"And money."

Abdulrahim laughed. "Yes, Hayati. And money."

"Enough that I can buy what I want."

"I know. I know. The Tomorrow Glass made that very clear."

She laughed.

"A few children," he added.

"A few."

"Travel."

"Yes."

"Peace."

Sun'dus became quiet.

"Most of all," she said.

Abdulrahim nodded.

"Most of all."

For a while they sat without speaking.

Above them, the Faraway Realm showed two skies at once.

Asterra's stars on one side.

Zahraan's on the other.

The same moon in the middle.

Abdulrahim stood and walked toward the stream.

Sun'dus did the same.

They placed their palms against the invisible line that separated their light-forms.

Their hands appeared perfectly matched.

Still no warmth.

Not yet.

Abdulrahim looked at her through the silver glow.
"Do you know what I am going to do when the Gate finally opens?"

Sun'dus smiled. "You tell me every week."

"I am going to hug you."

"I know."

"Very tight."

"I know."

"Probably too tight."

"Definitely."

"And cry."

"Also definitely."

He laughed.

Then his expression became gentle.

"And I am going to thank Allah that we reached it."

Sun'dus's smile changed.

Softer now.

"Insha'Allah."

"Insha'Allah."

The moon moved higher.

The Realm began to dim, telling them it was late.

Years ago, a closing mirror had frightened Abdulrahim because every goodbye felt too much like loss.

Now he understood the difference between goodbye and goodnight.

Sun'dus stepped toward her doorway.

"Sleep," she told him.

"You first."

"No."

"Still stubborn."

"You liked that from the beginning."

Abdulrahim smiled.

"Maybe."

"Goodnight, Hayati."

He looked at her one more time before the doorway closed.

"Goodnight, Hayati."

Sun'dus disappeared into Zahraan.

Abdulrahim remained in the Rose Mirror Court for another minute.

The golden thread stayed visible across the water.

He knew it was only magic reflecting a real bond.

The magic was not what would save them.

They would have to keep choosing honesty.

Patience.

Forgiveness.

Faith.

Growth.

They would have to finish the road themselves.

But the future no longer felt like an empty space.

Somewhere beyond the closed True Gate was a morning Abdulrahim had dreamed about for years.

A door would open.

Sun'dus would stand there.

For the first time, no mirror would separate them.

He would take her hand and feel warmth instead of light.

He would kiss her forehead.

He would hold her until both of them laughed through tears.

Maybe he would still struggle to believe it was real.

Maybe that disbelief would take days.

Maybe years later, in the middle of an ordinary evening in the home they had built, he would look at her and still remember the boy staring through a magical mirror at a girl from a kingdom impossibly far away.

And maybe he would smile because the distance had once seemed larger than the future.

It was not.

Abdulrahim turned toward his doorway.

Before leaving, he looked back at the empty seat where Sun'dus had been.

"Until the Gate opens," he whispered.

The Realm answered with a small movement of roses in the night wind.

Then he returned home.

The moon remained above Asterra.

The same moon remained above Zahraan.
Two kingdoms.

Two people.

One long road still unfinished.

And somewhere between them, a story still being written.

Hayati.

Not the end.

Only the part before they finally touch.

Before leaving the Realm that final night, Sun'dus turned back toward Abdulrahim.

"Do you know something?" she asked.

"What?"

"When we finally meet, the Realm will probably feel small."

Abdulrahim looked around the place that had once seemed endless.

"Maybe."

"This place carried our whole relationship."

"Not the whole thing."

"What do you mean?"

"It carried our voices. We carried the relationship."

Sun'dus smiled.

"That was actually good."

"Write it down. It may never happen again."

She laughed.

Then they became quiet.

Abdulrahim thought about the first night: the public court, his refusal to show a picture, the stubborn girl whose voice had made him curious, and the seeing mirror he opened only for her.

If someone had told him then that this girl would become part of his prayers, his plans, his arguments, his peace, his motivation, and his picture of marriage, he would not have believed them.

The story had not been straight.
That mattered.

A perfect road would not have taught them what this one had.

They knew how easily people could hurt each other when fear spoke louder than love.

They knew what silence felt like.

They knew how much an apology mattered when it came with change.

They knew that coming back was meaningful only if they learned something before returning.

They knew that love could be peaceful without being effortless.

And they knew that waiting for a halal beginning was not losing time.

It was choosing the kind of beginning they wanted to remember without regret.

Sun'dus moved toward her doorway again.

"Now sleep," she said.

"You first."

"Abdulrahim."

He smiled.

Some things, apparently, did not need to change.

After her doorway faded, Abdulrahim did one last thing before leaving the Faraway Realm. He opened the same magical book he had once kept almost empty. For years he had refused to let strangers walk through his memories. He still felt the same. Most of his life did not belong to the world.

But one page had never felt like a loss of privacy.

A private page.

For Sun'dus only.

He placed his hand over the paper and let the book take a memory that had not happened yet: a door opening after their marriage, Sun'dus standing on the other side, his hands finally holding hers, both of them laughing because they were crying too much to speak.

The book shimmered.

Under the memory, Abdulrahim wrote one line.

For the day this stops being a dream.

He closed the cover.

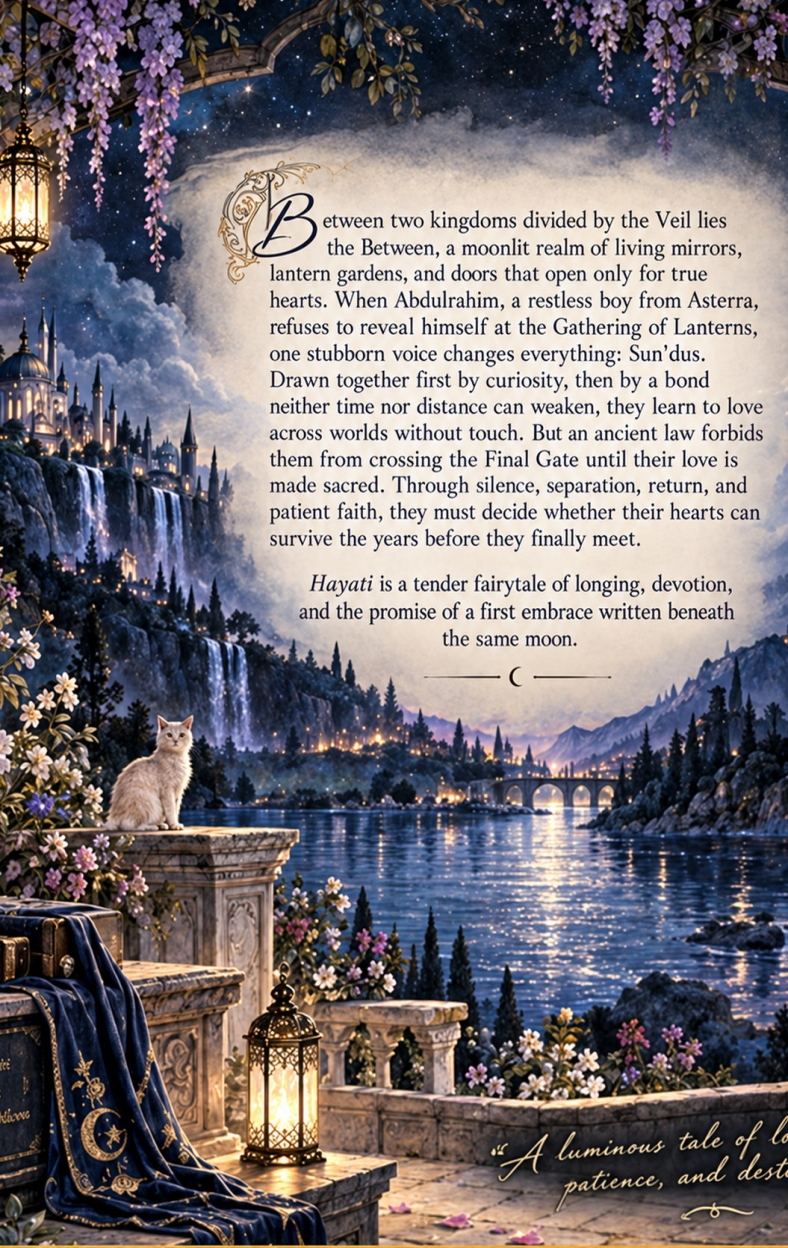
Once, the blank book had protected him from being known by strangers. Now it carried the one future he wanted to share with the person who had earned every page.

Abdulrahim smiled and returned to Asterra.

Far away, in Zahraan, Sun'dus's book gave a small golden glow beside her bed.

She would find the private page in the morning.
And the story would continue.



A detailed illustration of a magical night scene. In the foreground, a white cat sits on a stone balcony. To the left, a blue patterned cloth with a crescent moon and star hangs over a dark chest. A glowing lantern sits on the balcony. In the background, a castle with many spires sits on a cliff with waterfalls. A river flows through the landscape, with a bridge in the distance. The sky is dark with stars and a crescent moon. Purple wisteria hangs from the top of the frame.

*B*etween two kingdoms divided by the Veil lies the Between, a moonlit realm of living mirrors, lantern gardens, and doors that open only for true hearts. When Abdulrahim, a restless boy from Asterra, refuses to reveal himself at the Gathering of Lanterns, one stubborn voice changes everything: Sun'dus. Drawn together first by curiosity, then by a bond neither time nor distance can weaken, they learn to love across worlds without touch. But an ancient law forbids them from crossing the Final Gate until their love is made sacred. Through silence, separation, return, and patient faith, they must decide whether their hearts can survive the years before they finally meet.

Hayati is a tender fairytale of longing, devotion, and the promise of a first embrace written beneath the same moon.



“A luminous tale of love, patience, and destiny.”